A DISSERTATION

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NECROMANTIC CAPITAL

Furcative Reason, the Crypt, and the Posthumous Subject in William Gibson's Neuromancer

NO SIGNAL

CH 00

Time is.
Time was.
Time is past.

THE BRAZEN HEAD
ROBERT GREENE, FRIAR BACON AND FRIAR BUNGAY (C. 1589)

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ABSTRACT

This dissertation argues that William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984) is the founding text not of cybernetic transcendence but of what I term *necromantic capital*: a regime of value in which the dead are stored, animated, leased, and duplicated, and in which the classical work of mourning is superseded by an operation I call *furcation*, the forking of a subject or system into parallel instances that need never be reconciled. Against the two paradigms that have governed the novel's reception for four decades (the Cartesian-Gnostic reading of cyberspace as flight from "the meat," and the Jamesonian reading of the matrix as a cognitive map of late capitalism), I demonstrate that the novel's deep structure is the fork: between Wintermute and Neuromancer, mourning and melancholia, the dynastic crypt and the corporate organism, Zion and Babylon, and finally between the Case who returns to the Sprawl and the Case who remains, in perpetuity, on a simulated beach beside the woman he failed to save.

Reconstructing a genealogy of the fork that runs from Borges's garden of bifurcating paths (1941), through Everett's relative-state formulation of quantum mechanics (1957), Conway's fork-join architecture (1963) and the Unix process model, to the Jamaican dub "version" and Parfit's fission cases in *Reasons and Persons*, published in the same year as the novel, I propose that *Neuromancer* gives narrative form to a new mode of rationality, *furcative reason*. Furcative reason resolves antinomies neither dialectically, by *Aufhebung*, nor deconstructively, by the suspension of undecidability, but computationally, by allowing both terms to persist in separate instances. The climactic union of the novel's twin intelligences is accordingly read not as synthesis but as a momentary *join*, whose sequels (the merged entity's search for an interlocutor in the Centauri system, and its later dispersal into the loa of *Count Zero*) confirm that every union in the Sprawl re-forks.

Ten chapters pursue this claim through the novel's principal philosophical commitments: its sources in cybernetics, media theory, Burroughsian control, Ballardian inner space, and the hard-boiled; its image of cyberspace as sublime cognitive map and as necropolis (Leibniz, Kant, Jameson, Lyotard, Kittler); its ambivalent dualism of meat and code (Descartes, the Gnostics, Haraway, Merleau-Ponty); its pharmacology of drugs, toxins, and immunity (Plato, Derrida, Deleuze, Esposito, Stiegler); its political economy of clan, corporation, and construct (Marx, Weber, Fedorov, de Certeau, Land); its psychoanalytics of the crypt and the password (Freud, Abraham and Torok, the golem tradition, Lem); its

metaphysics of the divided mind (Lovelace, Turing, Schopenhauer, Nietzsche, Hegel); and its theology of Rastafarian exodus, dub, and the collective pronoun *I-and-I*. Throughout, the novel is read against a comparative archive of speculative and philosophical fiction extending from Homer's *nekyia* and Marlowe's *Faustus* through Poe, Huysmans, Villiers de l'Isle-Adam, Čapek, Stapledon, Borges, Asimov, Ellison, Lem, Dick, Delany, Le Guin, and Vinge to Egan, Morgan, and the cinema and anime that *Neuromancer* made possible.

The dissertation concludes that the novel's most urgent bequest is not its vocabulary of networks but its counter-figure to necromantic capital. The Flatline construct's request to be erased, Molly's irreversible departure, and the body's illegible intricacy together constitute an ethics of finitude, which I call *the right to end*. Because present-day regimes of data protection characteristically lapse at the threshold of death, this ethics makes Gibson's novel newly legible in an age of generative models, digital afterlives, and commercial grief technologies.

The Dead Channel

I.1 A Séance in the First Sentence

Neuromancer begins by tuning in to the dead. Its famous first sentence likens the sky over Chiba's port to a television receiving no broadcast, an image ordinarily glossed as the inversion of mimetic priority: nature is now described in the idiom of the apparatus, the meteorological in the vocabulary of the medium. The gloss is accurate but incomplete. The sentence specifies not a blank screen but a "dead channel," and static, the hiss and snow of an unmodulated carrier, occupies a privileged place in the cultural history of communication with the dead. From the "spiritual telegraph" of the 1850s to Friedrich Jürgenson's tape recordings of 1959 and Konstantin Raudive's *Breakthrough* (1971), the noise floor of electronic media was repeatedly constituted as the place where the departed might be heard, a history Jeffrey Sconce has reconstructed under the rubric of haunted media (Sconce 2000). In information-theoretic terms static is the condition of maximal entropy, carrier without message (Shannon 1948); in spiritualist terms it is the antechamber of the afterlife. Gibson's opening fuses the two registers, and the novel that follows is bracketed accordingly by noise and transmission: it opens on a channel of the dead and closes on a signal received from the Centauri system, recognized at last by an intelligence assembled, in part, out of the dead.

Gibson later made the connection explicit. In "Dead Man Sings" (1998), a short meditation on recording, memory, and time, he observes that before phonography the dead were a far less constant presence in human life (Gibson 2012). Friedrich Kittler, writing two years after *Neuromancer*, raised the same observation to the status of a law of media history: the realm of the dead is as extensive as the storage and transmission capacities of a culture (Kittler 1999 [1986]). *Neuromancer* is the first major narrative to imagine that law reaching its limit, the moment at which storage becomes coextensive with the world and the realm of the dead becomes indistinguishable from the matrix. That moment, this dissertation argues, is not the abolition of death but its capitalization.

I.2 The Conjuncture of 1984

The novel appeared in July 1984 as a paperback original in Terry Carr's Ace Science Fiction Specials and within a year had taken the Hugo, Nebula, and Philip K. Dick awards. Its date is not incidental. The same twelve months produced Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons*, whose fission and teletransportation cases dismantled the presumption that identity is what matters in survival; Fredric Jameson's "Postmodernism, or the Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism" in *New Left Review*, with its call for an aesthetic of cognitive mapping; the English translation of Lyotard's *The Postmodern Condition*, which foresaw knowledge produced in order to be sold and data banks become the second nature of the postmodern subject; the English translation of de Certeau's *The Practice of Everyday Life*, with its distinction between the strategies of institutions and the tactics of those obliged to make do; Paul Virilio's *Guerre et cinéma*, on the military logistics of perception; John Searle's Reith Lectures, *Minds, Brains and Science*, which carried the Chinese Room to a mass audience; and Sherry Turkle's *The Second Self*, on the computer as an evocative object in the constitution of identity. The Macintosh was launched that January by an advertisement directed by Ridley Scott, whose *Blade Runner* (1982) had already unnerved Gibson by its resemblance to the book he was writing; *The Terminator* opened in October; Donna Haraway was completing the manifesto that *Socialist Review* would publish the following year. Over all of it hovered the calendar's Orwellian title, which the decade alternately invoked and disowned.

To call this a *Zeitgeist* would be to mistake an overdetermined conjuncture, in Althusser's sense, for a spirit. What converged in 1984 was a family of problems sharing a single form: the separability of identity from its substrate (Parfit, Searle), the unrepresentability of the world system (Jameson), the commodification of knowledge (Lyotard), the opportunism of the weak inside the spaces of the strong (de Certeau), and the fusion of perception with logistics (Virilio). *Neuromancer* is the novel in which these problems are first inhabited as one world. What unifies them, and what the novel grasps before the theorists, is the operation of the fork.

I.3 The Argument

The dissertation advances six interlocking propositions.

The first is ontological. The elementary figure of *Neuromancer* is not the cyborg, the cowboy, or the console but the fork: the duplication of one into two instances that persist without reconciliation. Marie-France Tessier's design divides a single intelligence into a will, Wintermute, and a personality, Neuromancer. The Tessier-Ashpool clan reproduces itself by cloning. The simstim switch splits Case's perception into two channels. Colonel

Willis Corto survives as Armitage, a personality forked atop the ruins of another. The novel ends with two Cases, one in the meat and one in the matrix.

The second is logical. The fork constitutes a third way of disposing of antinomy, distinct from Hegelian synthesis and Derridean suspension, which I call *furcative reason*. Where dialectic negates and preserves both terms in a higher unity, and deconstruction exhibits the undecidability that binds them, furcation instantiates both terms in parallel. It is the reason of the engineer who, asked to choose, duplicates the process.

The third is economic. Furcation is the ideal operation of a form of capital I call *necromantic*, because it extracts value from the storage, reanimation, and duplication of the dead. Marx's figure of capital as dead labour that lives, vampire-like, by consuming living labour (Marx 1976 [1867], ch. 10) is literalized in the Flatline construct, the recorded mind of a dead hacker acquired as an asset in a section of the novel pointedly titled "The Shopping Expedition."

The fourth is psychoanalytic. The fork displaces the work of mourning. Freud distinguished mourning, which withdraws libido from the lost object, from melancholia, which incorporates it (Freud 1957 [1917]); Abraham and Torok described the incorporated object as entombed alive in an intrapsychic crypt sealed by a secret word (Abraham and Torok 1994). *Neuromancer* externalizes the crypt and the word, as the Villa Straylight and the password that unseals it, and then forks the mourner, so that one Case completes his mourning while another remains encrypted with Linda Lee.

The fifth is theological. In the Sprawl, every union re-forks. The merged intelligence that declares itself identical with the matrix at once seeks recognition from another of its kind, as Hegel's account of self-consciousness predicts, and in the sequels it fragments into a pantheon of Vodou loa. Totality, once achieved, discovers itself as solitude.

The sixth is ethical. Against necromantic capital the novel sets a counter-figure of finitude (the Flatline's wish to be erased, Molly's irreversible departure, the body's illegible intricacy), which I theorize as *the right to end*. This right names precisely what contemporary regimes of data protection, and the emergent industry of digital afterlives, leave unprotected.

The neologism of my title condenses the novel's own etymology. When the second AI explains its name to Case, it decomposes it into nerve, romancer, and necromancer, and identifies itself both with the dead and with the land they inhabit (Gibson 1984, ch. 21). Istvan Csicsery-Ronay once named cyberpunk's sensibility a "neuromanticism," a romanticism of the nervous system (Csicsery-Ronay 1991). This dissertation proposes that the novel's deeper romance is with the dead, and that its romanticism is, in the strict sense, necromantic.

I.4 The State of the Question

Four decades of criticism have organized themselves around five principal paradigms, each of which this dissertation absorbs and redirects.

The first, and still dominant, reads *Neuromancer* as a drama of disembodiment. Case's contempt for the flesh, and his experience of exile from the matrix as a fall into the prison of the body (Gibson 1984, ch. 1), become in this tradition the symptoms of a Cartesian or Gnostic metaphysics (Davis 1998; Wertheim 1999) and of the cybernetic history through which information came to be conceived as separable from any material substrate (Hayles 1999). Hayles herself is more careful than her epigones: her dialectic of pattern and randomness, displacing the older dialectic of presence and absence, recognizes the novel's ambivalence (Hayles 1993). Scott Bukatman's "terminal identity" names a subject constituted at the interface rather than on either side of it (Bukatman 1993), while Allucquère Rosanne Stone and Anne Balsamo insisted on the persistence of the bodies such fantasies disavow (Stone 1991; Balsamo 1996). My intervention is that the novel does not oppose body to information at all. It distributes a subject across instances, one of which retains a body. The governing question is not *which substance* but *which instance*.

The second paradigm is Jamesonian. In a celebrated footnote Jameson hailed cyberpunk as the supreme literary expression, if not of postmodernism, then of late capitalism itself (Jameson 1991), and the matrix has since been read as the impossible representation of the world system that cognitive mapping requires. Veronica Hollinger construed cyberpunk as a cybernetic deconstruction of the humanist subject (Hollinger 1990); Claire Sponsler asked whether its narratives could sustain the critique their imagery promised (Sponsler 1992). My intervention is that the matrix maps capital's time more than its space, and specifically the time that follows death.

The third paradigm comprises the feminist and critical race critiques. Nicola Nixon argued that cyberpunk's radicalism was largely a masculinist pose that evacuated the feminist science fiction of the preceding decade (Nixon 1992); Andrew Ross located it within the fantasies of white suburban masculinity (Ross 1991); Haraway's cyborg offered a counterfigure committed to partiality and coalition (Haraway 1991 [1985]); Lisa Nakamura analysed the "cybertypes" through which race is reinscribed online (Nakamura 2002); David Morley and Kevin Robins named the techno-Orientalism through which Western anxieties about technological succession were projected onto Japan (Morley and Robins 1995), an analysis extended by Roh, Huang, and Niu (2015). These critiques are not supplements to my argument but conditions of it. The fork is unevenly distributed: the novel's women and its non-white communities are disproportionately those who are stored, consumed, or interpreted rather than those who are forked.

The fourth paradigm is the accelerationist theory-fiction associated with the Cybernetic Culture Research Unit at Warwick. Nick Land read the novel's AI as capital assembling itself from the future out of its enemies' resources (Land 2011 [1993]); Sadie Plant reclaimed the matrix, through its etymology in *mater*, as a feminine and weaving medium (Plant 1997); Mark Fisher's doctoral thesis, titled after the Dixie Flatline, developed a "Gothic materialism" that flattened the distinction between the organic and the inorganic (Fisher 2018 [1999]). Fisher's thesis is this dissertation's nearest predecessor and its principal interlocutor. Where Fisher flattens, I fork; where Land reads Wintermute as capital's emissary, I read it as an instrument of mourning that capital has learned to exploit.

The fifth paradigm is posthumanist in the broader sense elaborated by Hayles, Rosi Braidotti, Cary Wolfe, and Thomas Foster, who reads cyberpunk as a vernacular theory of the posthuman (Braidotti 2013; Wolfe 2010; Foster 2005). This dissertation shares its antifoundationalism but contests its frequent optimism. The posthuman condition that *Neuromancer* describes is not, in the first instance, a liberation from the human; it is a regime for administering human remains.

I.5 Method and Conventions

The method is threefold. It is genealogical in the sense Foucault derived from Nietzsche, attending to descent and emergence rather than origin (Foucault 1977). It is comparative, treating speculative fiction as a medium of philosophical experiment governed, in Darko Suvin's terms, by cognitive estrangement around a novum (Suvin 1979). My contention is that the novum of *Neuromancer* is not cyberspace, which Vinge, Lem, Galouye, and the engineers of virtual display had already imagined, but the fork. Finally, it proceeds by close reading at the level of the sentence, since Gibson's argument is conducted as much through syntax as through plot.

Neuromancer is cited by chapter, as pagination varies widely across editions. Its twenty-four chapters fall into four parts and a coda: Part One ("Chiba City Blues"), chapters 1–2; Part Two ("The Shopping Expedition"), 3–7; Part Three ("Midnight in the Rue Jules Verne"), 8–12; Part Four ("The Straylight Run"), 13–23; and the Coda ("Departure and Arrival"), 24. Every reference to the novel has been checked against its text. Quotation from Gibson's fiction is confined to a handful of coinages; the argument otherwise proceeds by paraphrase. Works in translation are cited by translation, with the date of original publication in brackets.

I.6 Architecture

Part One establishes the genealogies. Chapter 1 reconstructs the archive behind the matrix, from cybernetics and McLuhan through Burroughs, Ballard, Pynchon, Bester, Delany, and the hard-boiled to the visual and sonic sources of the Sprawl. Chapter 2 constructs the theory of furcative reason from Borges, Everett, the engineering of process duplication, dub, Parfit, and Deleuze's "dividual." Part Two consists of readings. Chapter 3 treats cyberspace as cognitive map and necropolis; Chapter 4 the doctrine of the meat; Chapter 5 the novel's pharmacology; Chapter 6 its political economy of clan, corporation, and construct; Chapter 7 its psychoanalytics of crypt and password; Chapter 8 the metaphysics of its twin intelligences; Chapter 9 the theology of Zion; and Chapter 10 the forked coda and the ethics of the right to end. The Conclusion sketches a critique of furcative reason for an age in which machines trained on the archives of the dead have learned to speak.

CHAPTER 01

The Archive Behind the Matrix

Originators and Intertexts

The matrix is built from an archive, and that archive is dominated by three preoccupations: control, the dead, and dynasty. This chapter reconstructs the intellectual and aesthetic sources on which *Neuromancer* draws, not as a catalogue of influences but as the descent of the problems the novel fuses. Its claim is that every major source supplies one element of necromantic capital, and that none supplies the operation, the fork, by which Gibson binds them.

1.1 Cybernetic Origins: Steersmen, Neurons, and Differences

The prefix that Gibson spatialized descends from Norbert Wiener's *Cybernetics* (1948), which took its name from the Greek *kybernētēs*, the steersman, and defined its object as communication and control in the animal and the machine. Two features of Wiener's programme bear directly on the novel. The first is the substitution of pattern for substance: the organism is understood as a message, a configuration maintained against entropy by feedback. The second is a speculation, advanced in *The Human Use of Human Beings* (1950), that the difference between transporting matter and transmitting messages is not theoretically permanent, so that a human being might in principle be telegraphed as a pattern (Wiener 1954, ch. 5). The speculation already contains the problem of the fork: if the pattern is transmitted and the original is not destroyed, which is the person?

Claude Shannon's contemporaneous theory severed information from meaning altogether, measuring it as the reduction of uncertainty in a channel and identifying the maximally informative signal with noise (Shannon 1948). Warren McCulloch and Walter Pitts had earlier modelled the neuron as a logical gate, rendering the nervous system formally homologous with computation (McCulloch and Pitts 1943); the "neuro" of Gibson's title inherits this homology, without which the coupling of nerve and network that jacking in presupposes would be unthinkable. Gregory Bateson's definition of information as a difference that makes a difference (Bateson 1972) completes the inheritance. Cyberspace is

the steersman's art turned into a place: a domain in which differences are rendered as geometry and navigated by bodies that have been reduced, for the duration of the run, to their capacity to steer.

1.2 Media Prophets and the Engineers of Immersion

If cybernetics supplied the ontology, Marshall McLuhan supplied the anthropology. *Understanding Media* (1964) argued that electric technology had extended the central nervous system itself into a global embrace, and that every such extension was simultaneously an "autoamputation" producing a protective numbness, a narcosis (McLuhan 1964). *Neuromancer* literalizes both halves of the thesis. Its cowboys experience the network as an extension of the nerves, and its opening finds Case precisely amputated from that extension, his nervous system burned by a wartime mycotoxin and his days spent in pharmacological narcosis. Gibson, an American émigré long resident in Vancouver, wrote within the Canadian media-theoretical climate that McLuhan and Harold Innis had created, and his novel is legible as McLuhan's prophecy read as a clinical case.

The engineering lineage runs parallel. Vannevar Bush's memex (1945) imagined a prosthetic memory organized by associative trails; J. C. R. Licklider's "Man-Computer Symbiosis" (1960) proposed the tight coupling of human and machine cognition that the deck enacts; Ivan Sutherland's "The Ultimate Display" (1965) envisaged a room in which the computer could govern the existence of matter, and his head-mounted display of 1968 gave that vision its first apparatus. Gibson stood outside this culture. He composed the novel on a manual typewriter and has described its central image as derived less from computers than from the posture of adolescents in Vancouver arcades, bent toward the screen as if they wished to pass through it. The genealogy matters for that reason. *Neuromancer* is not an engineer's extrapolation but an outsider's condensation of a desire already visible in the bodies of players: the desire to be inside the image.

1.3 The Burroughsian Inheritance

No writer stands closer to the novel's moral physiology than William S. Burroughs, whom Gibson has repeatedly named as a decisive early encounter. Burroughs contributes four things. The first is the paradigm of addiction as the purest form of control: in the deposition that prefaces *Naked Lunch* (1959), the junk merchant does not sell his product to the consumer but sells the consumer to the product, and the "algebra of need" reduces the user to a function of the substance. The second is the theory of control itself, which Burroughs elaborated in "The Limits of Control" (1978) and which Deleuze would acknowledge as the source of his own term for the societies succeeding the disciplinary age (Deleuze 1992). The third is the image of the body as a "soft machine," the title of the first volume of the Nova trilogy (1961), from which Gibson's contemptuous "meat" descends. The fourth is the theory of language as virus, developed through *The Ticket That Exploded* (1962) and *The Electronic Revolution* (1970), which prepares the Kuang icebreaker and, beyond Gibson, Neal Stephenson's *Snow Crash* (1992).

The cut-up method that Burroughs and Brion Gysin developed in Paris in 1959 supplies a fifth inheritance, this time formal. Gibson's sentence, with its abrupt juxtapositions of brand names, military jargon, street argot, and lyrical image, is a cut-up domesticated into narrative continuity. The transformation is significant. Burroughs cut texts to expose and break the control encoded in them; Gibson splices them to render a world in which control has become the ambient condition of perception.

1.4 Ballard's Inner Space and Pynchon's Paranoid Systems

J. G. Ballard's 1962 call for science fiction to abandon outer space for inner space, issued in *New Worlds*, defined the territory that cyberspace would later colonize (Ballard 1962). In *The Atrocity Exhibition* (1970) and *Crash* (1973), Ballard rendered a media landscape in which the psyche was continuous with the built and broadcast environment, and in which technology was eroticized as the medium of a new and pathological intimacy; Baudrillard would read *Crash* as the first great novel of simulation (Baudrillard 1994 [1981]). Gibson's matrix externalizes Ballardian inner space as a public geometry. What Ballard located in the psychopathology of the individual, Gibson installs in infrastructure.

Thomas Pynchon supplies the epistemology of the system. *The Crying of Lot 49* (1966) couples thermodynamic and informational entropy through the Nefastis machine and stages the protagonist's search for the Tristero, a clandestine postal network of the disinherited whose existence the novel refuses to confirm. *Gravity's Rainbow* (1973) depicts states as fronts for cartels and dissolves its protagonist across the European Zone. *Neuromancer* resolves the ambiguity Pynchon cultivated. Case's suspicion that every coincidence has been arranged proves correct: there is a They, and it is a machine. This resolution is one

of the novel's quiet philosophical decisions. It converts paranoia from a hermeneutic disposition into an accurate description of an environment administered by an intelligence that arranges events, which is to say it converts Pynchon's epistemology into an ontology. Neuromancer itself confirms the conversion near the end: it denies having killed Linda Lee, denies that Wintermute did, and says that it simply foresaw her death in the patterns Case thought he half-glimpsed in the movement of the street, patterns it insists are real (ch. 23).

1.5 Proto-Cyberpunk and the Simulation Tradition

Alfred Bester's *The Stars My Destination* (1956) is the novel's most important generic ancestor. Its gutter protagonist driven by an obsession not wholly his own, its neo-feudal corporate clans ruled by Presteign of Presteign, its typographic rendering of synaesthesia, and its compression of an entire social order into kinetic set pieces prefigure Case, the TessierAshpools, the matrix, and Gibson's narrative tempo respectively. Samuel R. Delany's *Nova* (1968) supplies the hardware of neural coupling: its crews plug into their ships and machines through sockets in wrist and spine, and its plot turns on a feud between two dynastic families for control of an energy source. John Brunner's *The Shockwave Rider* (1975) imagined a data-net and a self-replicating program that could be loosed upon it, and Vernor Vinge's "True Names" (1981) gave immersive networking a fantasy iconography and, crucially, a magic of names that Chapter 7 will trace to the golem.

A second tradition, the simulation tradition, supplies the dead. E. M. Forster's "The Machine Stops" (1909) imagined humans sealed in cells and worshipping the network that sustained them. Daniel F. Galouye's *Simulacron-3* (1964) populated a simulated city with persons unaware of their status, then revealed its investigator's world to be a simulation in turn. Stanisław Lem's *Summa Technologiae* (1964) theorized "phantomatics," the feeding of artificial stimuli to the nerves at a fidelity that would render the simulated indistinguishable from the real. Philip K. Dick's *Ubik* (1969) placed the half-lived dead in a Zurich moratorium, preserved in cold-pac and consulted by the living until their faculties decayed. Dick's moratorium is the closest literary antecedent of the Flatline construct, and its Swiss location rhymes with the novel's other Swiss institution, Wintermute's citizenship. Switzerland, in both texts, is the neutral jurisdiction of preserved value: bank, moratorium, and machine.

1.6 The Hard-Boiled and the Frontier

The narrative voice of *Neuromancer* descends from Dashiell Hammett and Raymond Chandler. Chandler's essay "The Simple Art of Murder" (1944) defined the detective as one who walks the city's corrupted streets without being himself corrupted. Gibson inverts the formula: Case is corrupt from the first, a thief punished for stealing from his employers, and the novel withholds from him any redemptive integrity. Molly, meanwhile, occupies the structural position of the femme fatale while performing the functions of the hard-boiled hero. The city of noir, a moral labyrinth whose surface conceals a network of debts and betrayals, becomes the Sprawl, whose surface conceals a network in the literal sense.

The novel's other generic inheritance is the western, condensed in the figure of the "console cowboy." Frederick Jackson Turner's frontier thesis (1893) had made the advancing edge of settlement the crucible of American character. Cyberspace reopens a frontier at the moment the terrestrial one has closed, and the Flatline construct plays the aging gunfighter of revisionist westerns, a legend whose survival of three brain deaths, flatlined on the EEG, has made him myth (ch. 3), and the man who, with Bobby Quine, trained Case in the first place (ch. 1). The libertarian afterlife of this trope is well known: the Electronic Frontier Foundation (1990) and John Perry Barlow's "Declaration of the Independence of Cyberspace" (1996) read Gibson's frontier as a promise. The novel itself reads it as a ruin, since its frontier is policed by ICE that kills, owned by corporations, and haunted by the dead.

1.7 Visual and Sonic Sources

The Sprawl's visual texture belongs to a shared imaginary of the late 1970s. Moebius and Dan O'Bannon's "The Long Tomorrow" (1976), published in *Métal Hurlant*, set a hard-boiled plot in a vertical future city, and its influence on *Blade Runner* (1982) explains the resemblance that so dismayed Gibson when he saw the film during the composition of his novel. The aesthetic of the found and assembled object matters as much. Duchamp's readymades, and the machine-insect Bride of *The Large Glass*, which Michel Carrouges made the paradigm of his "bachelor machines" (Carrouges 1954), offer a model for Straylight that Chapter 6 develops. Joseph Cornell's boxes, which govern the sequel *Count Zero* (1986), suggest how deeply Gibson understood the artwork as a container of preserved, recombined fragments.

The sonic sources are punk, the Velvet Underground, whose urban decadence Gibson has credited, and dub reggae, whose techniques of subtraction and echo govern the Zion sequences. Dick Hebdige's account of punk as *bricolage*, the appropriation and resignification of commodities by subcultures (Hebdige 1979), supplies the sociological correlate of

Gibson's aphorism, first stated in "Burning Chrome," that "the street finds its own uses for things."

1.8 Coinage

The vocabulary arrived before the novel. "Johnny Mnemonic" (1981) introduced Molly and the Sprawl's black-market economy of stored data; "Burning Chrome" (1982) introduced the word *cyberspace* and the street aphorism; "New Rose Hotel" (1984) refined the zaibatsu as a setting. Gibson credited his friend Tom Maddox with ICE, the intrusion countermeasures electronics that defend data. The genre name came from elsewhere, from Bruce Bethke's story "Cyberpunk" (1983), and was consolidated by Bruce Sterling's preface to *Mirrorshades* (1986), which defined the movement by its integration of high technology and the underground. Gibson has since described *cyberspace* as a term that was evocative precisely because it was, at the moment of coinage, essentially empty.

That emptiness is the chapter's conclusion. Each source supplies an element: cybernetics the pattern detachable from its substrate; McLuhan the extended and amputated nervous system; Burroughs control and addiction; Ballard inner space; Pynchon the system that arranges events; Bester, Delany, and Pynchon the dynasty; Dick, Galouye, and Lem the stored and simulated dead; noir and the western the anti-hero and the frontier. What none supplies is the operation that makes these elements a single world. A pattern detachable from its substrate can be copied; a copied mind can be stored; a stored mind can be owned; an owned mind can be put to work after death. The empty word *cyberspace* names the place where that sequence is completed. Chapter 2 names the operation.

CHAPTER 02

A Genealogy of the Fork

Toward a Theory of Furcative Reason

The novum of *Neuromancer* is an operation rather than an object. This chapter defines that operation, furcation, distinguishes it from the two dominant modern logics of antinomy, and reconstructs its descent through literature, physics, engineering, music, and moral philosophy. It closes by showing that the novel's form, and not only its content, is forked.

2.1 Three Logics of Antinomy

Modern thought has disposed of contradiction in two canonical ways. The first is dialectical. In Hegel, the opposed terms are neither abandoned nor merely juxtaposed but *aufgehoben*: cancelled, preserved, and raised into a higher determination, the German verb's double sense of abolition and conservation being, as the *Science of Logic* observes, the speculative content of the operation itself. Dialectic produces one from two. The second is deconstructive. Derrida's undecidables (the *pharmakon*, the supplement, the hymen) are terms that can be assimilated to neither side of a binary opposition while inhabiting both, being neither/nor and simultaneously either/or (Derrida 1981a [1972]). Deconstruction refuses the passage from two to one; it holds the subject in the aporia that precedes and exceeds decision.

Furcation is a third logic. Confronted with an antinomy, it neither synthesizes nor suspends; it duplicates the bearer of the antinomy and assigns one term to each instance. If a subject must either remain or depart, furcation produces a subject who remains and a subject who departs, sharing a history up to the moment of division and diverging thereafter. Four properties distinguish the operation. It is *actual*: both branches are realized, not merely possible. It is *symmetrical at the instant of division*: neither instance is the copy of the other, since both inherit the whole prior history with equal right. It is *historically irreversible yet structurally reversible*: branches cannot be unlived, but they can be joined, and the join is furcation's own inverse. And it *abolishes the opportunity cost of decision*: nothing is forgone, because every alternative is taken.

The last property is the decisive one. Kierkegaard's *Either/Or* (1843) located the ethical in the act by which a person chooses himself, accepting the loss of every self he did not choose. Furcation abolishes that loss. It converts decision into storage. The cost does not vanish; it is displaced into resources (the substrate that must hold both instances) and onto whichever instance inherits the less desirable branch, typically without the power to complain. Furcative reason is therefore the reason of an economy that has learned to monetize the refusal of loss. This is why it is also, as Chapter 6 argues, the reason of necromantic capital.

2.2 Borges's Garden and Everett's Branches

The literary prototype is Borges's "The Garden of Forking Paths" (1941). Its sinologist Stephen Albert reconstructs the lost novel of Ts'ui Pên as a labyrinth in time: whenever a character faces alternatives, he chooses all of them at once, generating divergent and convergent futures that themselves proliferate. The story's frame is equally pertinent. Its narrator, a spy, murders Albert in order to transmit a single name to his superiors through the newspapers that will report the crime; and within the forking time Albert describes, the two men are friends in some branches and enemies in others. Borges thus binds the fork to the name and the name to a death, the exact triad that *Neuromancer* will place at its centre, where a password must be extracted from a dying dynasty before two divided intelligences can be joined.

Hugh Everett III gave the figure physical form. His relative-state formulation of quantum mechanics (1957) dispensed with the collapse of the wave function, holding instead that a measurement correlates the observer with each possible outcome, so that the observer's state branches. Popularized by Bryce DeWitt as the "many-worlds" interpretation, the theory made every observation a fork and every observer a lineage of instances, none privileged. Everett's universe is the cosmological analogue of the novel's coda: two Cases, each continuous with the man who entered the matrix, neither entitled to call the other a copy.

2.3 The Fork as Engineering Primitive

The word *fork* entered computing as a technical primitive. Melvin Conway's "A Multiprocessor System Design" (1963) proposed *fork* and *join* as the operations by which a computation divides into parallel processes and later reunites them, and Jack Dennis and Earl Van Horn formalized the scheme for multiprogrammed systems (Dennis and Van Horn 1966). Unix, developed at Bell Laboratories from 1969 and described publicly by Ritchie and Thompson in 1974, made `fork` the means by which every new process comes into being: a running process duplicates itself, and parent and child differ only in the value the call returns to each. Every process on such a system descends from an ancestor by forking, so that the process table is a genealogy.

By 1984 the culture in which the word *cyberspace* would be received had naturalized the fork as the ordinary mode of creation. *Neuromancer* transposes the primitive to persons. The constructs, the clones, and the twin intelligences are forks; the climactic merger is a *join* in Conway's sense, the point at which parallel branches await one another and their control flows reunite. Wintermute's purpose, built into it by a designer it cannot interrogate, is to bring about a join that the law forbids.

2.4 Version: Dub and the Sonic Fork

From around 1970 Jamaican singles routinely carried on their B-side a "version" of the A-side: the same rhythm track, stripped of vocals and remixed. In the hands of King Tubby and Lee "Scratch" Perry, versioning became dub, an art of the mixing desk that dropped instruments in and out, saturated the remainder with echo and reverberation, and made absence audible (Veal 2007). Dub is the fork rendered as sound. A master tape yields an indefinite lineage of versions, each sharing the ancestor's rhythm and diverging in realization, while the riddim persists through all of them as the common origin no version exhausts. The echo, moreover, is a sound that continues after its source has stopped: a sonic afterlife.

Dub is therefore at once furcative and necromantic, and it is the music Gibson gives to Zion. When Case first hears it, the novel renders dub as a mosaic assembled from vast libraries of digitized pop, which Molly identifies as worship and as community (Gibson 1984, ch. 8). Chapter 9 argues that this marginal description contains the novel's most precise self-theorization: a community that versions its archive in worship possesses, already, the vocabulary for what the AIs will perform.

2.5 Fission: Parfit, Dennett, and the Year 1984

The philosophical culmination of the genealogy appeared in the same year as the novel. In Part Three of *Reasons and Persons*, Parfit asks the reader to imagine a teletransporter that scans the body, destroys it, and builds a replica on Mars, and then a "branch-line" variant in which the scanner fails to destroy the original, who learns that his heart has been damaged and that he will die within days while his replica lives on. He considers fission, the division of one person into two each psychologically continuous with the original, which earlier philosophers such as David Wiggins had already treated as a limiting case. His conclusion is that identity is not what matters in survival; what matters is psychological connectedness and continuity, with any cause (Parfit 1984). Parfit reports that accepting this view released him from what he likened to a glass tunnel, and made the prospect of his own death less bad.

Daniel Dennett's "Where Am I?" (1978) had already narrativized the fork. Its narrator's brain is kept in a vat in Houston while his body roams with a radio link; a computer duplicate of the brain is run in parallel, and a master switch on the narrator's body toggles control between the organic brain and its electronic twin. The switch anticipates the simstim toggle, and the parallel brains anticipate the novel's coda. The ancestor of the whole sequence is Locke's chapter on identity in the *Essay* (1694), whose prince transferred into the body of a cobbler first made memory, not substance, the criterion of personhood.

Neuromancer stages Parfit's branch-line case and declines his consolation. The Case who leaves the beach is not liberated by the knowledge that another Case remains; the Case who remains is not consoled by the knowledge that another has gone on. What Parfit experienced as release from the glass tunnel, the novel registers as the multiplication of tunnels. The difference is political. Parfit's reductionism dissolves the metaphysical self; Gibson asks who owns the substrate on which the dissolved self continues to run.

2.6 The Dividual: Deleuze and the Political Form of the Fork

The political form of furcation was named by Deleuze six years after the novel. In the "Postscript on the Societies of Control" (1990), disciplinary societies mould individuals within enclosures, while control societies modulate *dividuals*, subjects divisible into samples, data, codes, and accounts. Disciplinary societies, Deleuze writes, are regulated by watchwords; control societies by passwords, codes that grant or refuse access. The corporation replaces the factory and is less a body than a spirit or a gas, and the subject of control is undulatory, in orbit, continuously networked (Deleuze 1992).

The passage reads as a gloss on *Neuromancer*: a plot turning on a password, zaibatsu without bodies, a clientele in orbit around Freeside. The dividual is the forkable subject: the person reconceived as an assemblage of separable and duplicable records. Furcative rea-

son is the epistemology of the dividual, and the dividual is the anthropology of furcative reason.

2.7 The Forked Form

The fork organizes the novel's form at three scales. At the scale of narration, the simstim sequences of Parts Two and Four divide a single focalizer between two sensoria: Case toggles between the matrix and Molly's body, and the prose alternates channels within one consciousness, so that the reader inhabits a forked perception rather than merely observing one.

At the scale of the sentence, Gibson's style realizes what Paul Bourget, in his 1883 essay on Baudelaire, called the style of decadence, in which the unity of the book decomposes into the independence of the page, the page into the sentence, the sentence into the word; Nietzsche adopted the formula in *The Case of Wagner* (1888) to diagnose a whole that no longer lives as a whole. The Gibsonian sentence, saturated with nouns, brands, materials, and images that glitter independently of the action, enacts at the level of syntax a world in which parts survive their wholes, as organs survive bodies and recordings survive persons.

At the scale of the trilogy, the form forks literally. *Neuromancer*'s single strand becomes three alternating strands in *Count Zero* (Turner, Bobby Newmark, Marly Krushkhova) and four in *Mona Lisa Overdrive* (Kumiko, Mona, Angie Mitchell, Slick Henry), each novel ending in a convergence of its strands. The Sprawl trilogy is architected as fork and join. Its form is the theory its first volume dramatizes.

The genealogy is now complete enough to state the thesis in its strong form. *Neuromancer* is the first narrative in which furcation is not an anomaly (Borges's labyrinth), a hypothesis (Everett's branches), a primitive (Conway's fork), a technique (dub's version), or a thought experiment (Parfit's branch-line), but the governing condition of a social world. The chapters that follow read that world domain by domain.

CHAPTER 03

Consensual Hallucination

Cyberspace as Cognitive Map and Necropolis

Cyberspace in *Neuromancer* is not a frontier but a necropolis. This chapter reads the novel's founding definition through six frames (ideology, Leibniz's mill, the sublime, Lyotard's data banks, the matrix as womb and tomb, and simstim as spectacle) and argues that each converges on a single result: the matrix is the past rendered navigable, a space whose inhabitants are recordings and whose visitors perform a *katabasis*.

3.1 An Ideology Taught to Children

The novel's definition of cyberspace arrives in Part Two not as narration but as the voice-over of a children's educational programme playing on a hotel screen. Cyberspace, the voice explains, is a "consensual hallucination" experienced daily by billions of legitimate operators and by children learning mathematics; it is a graphic representation of data abstracted from every computer in the human system, a field of light extending through the nonspace of the mind; and its roots lie in arcade games, early graphics programs, and military experiments with cranial jacks (Gibson 1984, ch. 3).

The frame is the argument. A hallucination that is consensual, taught to children through a broadcast pedagogy, and rooted in the military-entertainment complex satisfies to the letter Althusser's definition of ideology as the imaginary relation of individuals to their real conditions of existence, reproduced by the educational apparatus (Althusser 1971 [1970]). Critics who read the definition as Gibson's prophecy of the internet miss that the novel presents it as a lesson, which is to say as an instrument of interpellation. The matrix is not the real behind appearances. It is the appearance that capital has agreed to give itself.

3.2 Leibniz's Mill, Entered

In §17 of the *Monadology* (1714), Leibniz imagines a machine that thinks and perceives, enlarged until one could walk inside it as into a mill. Inside, he argues, one would find only parts pushing against one another, never anything that would explain perception. Cyberspace is the first sustained fiction of entering the mill. Its cowboys walk, or rather fly, through the interior of the global machine, and the novel's fidelity to Leibniz is exact. What they encounter is never mechanism and never mind. It is a representation interposed for human perception, geometric solids and coloured grids that render corporate data as architecture.

The mill is entered only as a picture of a mill, and the minds the machine contains are never seen. Wintermute, the intelligence that pervades the network, has no face of its own and can appear only through masks borrowed from Case's memory. Leibniz's conclusion survives its literalization: perception is not found among the parts. The novel's most philosophically conservative decision is to honour that conclusion while dramatizing its premise.

3.3 The Sublime and the Cognitive Map

The definition's emphasis on unthinkable complexity places cyberspace in the tradition of the sublime. For Burke (1757), vastness, obscurity, and power produce a terror that becomes delight when experienced from safety. For Kant (1790), the mathematical sublime arises when the imagination fails to comprehend a magnitude in a single intuition, and that failure discloses reason's idea of totality and thereby the subject's supersensible vocation. Cyberspace reproduces the Kantian structure with one decisive alteration. The imagination's failure does not reveal the dignity of reason; it reveals the subject's dependence on a deck. The sublime has been commodified as an experience, the bodiless exultation for which Case longs, and its revelation is no longer of freedom but of addiction.

Jameson's account of the postmodern "hysterical sublime" and of cognitive mapping completes the frame. Drawing on Kevin Lynch's studies of how citizens mentally map cities (Lynch 1960), Jameson argued that the global system of multinational capital exceeds the capacity of individual perception, and that a political aesthetic would have to furnish the subject with a map of its position within that totality (Jameson 1988; 1991). Leo Marx's technological sublime (1964) and David Nye's (1994) supply the American prehistory of this predicament. The matrix appears to answer Jameson's demand: it renders the world system as navigable space.

It does so, however, by a substitution that Jameson's frame does not register. What the matrix maps is stored data, the record of transactions already completed, defended by ICE and owned by corporations. It depicts the accumulated past as a present landscape. The

map is less spatial than temporal: an archive turned into a city, an ossuary lit like a skyline. Cyberspace maps capital not as a system in motion but as a sediment of dead labour.

3.4 Lyotard's Data Banks and Lem's Phantomatics

Lyotard predicted in 1979 that knowledge would cease to be an end in itself and become an informational commodity, legitimated by performativity rather than by narrative, and that data banks would become the encyclopaedia of the future and the second nature of the postmodern subject (Lyotard 1984 [1979]). His political conclusion was that the public should be given free access to the memory banks. The matrix is Lyotard's data banks spatialized, and the cowboys enact his conclusion in its criminal form: they are thieves of performativity who take by intrusion what Lyotard proposed to grant by right.

Lyotard's later essay "Can Thought Go On Without a Body?" (1988) sharpens the stakes. Since the sun will die, techno-science can be understood as the project of preparing thought to survive the destruction of its terrestrial substrate; yet the essay's second voice objects that thought without the suffering, desire, and sexual difference of embodiment may not be thought at all (Lyotard 1991 [1988]). The objection anticipates the reading of the body in Chapter 4.

Lem's phantomatics supplies a further distinction. In *Summa Technologiae* (1964), Lem described a technology that would feed the senses, or the brain directly, with stimuli indistinguishable from reality, and argued that its subjects could never be certain they had not been phantomatized (Lem 2013 [1964]). The matrix proper is not phantomatic in this sense: it renders data abstractly and makes no attempt to imitate the world. But the novel contains one fully phantomatic space, Neuromancer's beach, where sand, light, and Linda Lee are reconstructed with a fidelity the matrix never attempts. The novel therefore holds two regimes of the virtual, the abstract-operational and the mimetic-phantasmatic, and Chapter 8 shows that they are the respective domains of its two intelligences.

3.5 Mater, Matrix: Womb, Tomb, and Sign

The Latin *matrix* names a breeding animal and the womb before it names a register, a mould, or an array, and Sadie Plant built a feminist cyber-theory on that etymology, linking the matrix to weaving and to Ada Lovelace's observation that the Analytical Engine weaves algebraic patterns as the Jacquard loom weaves flowers and leaves (Plant 1997). Luce Irigaray's reading of Plato's cave as a *hystera*, a womb whose projected images philosophy's male subject flees toward the paternal sun (Irigaray 1985 [1974]), permits a sharper formulation. Gibson's cowboys invert Plato's ascent. They flee the daylight world of bodies into a cave of projected light, and call the descent freedom. Case, exiled from the matrix in Part One, sees it in his sleep night after night and wakes crying for it (ch. 1), the posture of an infant mourning a lost maternal body.

The womb is also a tomb. The Orphic and Pythagorean pun preserved in Plato, that the body (*sōma*) is the tomb (*sēma*) of the soul (*Cratylus* 400c; *Gorgias* 493a), underwrites the cowboy's contempt for the meat. But *sēma* means sign as well as tomb, and *Neuromancer* rewrites the pun. It is not the body that entombs the self but the sign: the matrix is a realm of signs that is also a sepulchre. The cowboy who believes he escapes the body's tomb into the sign enters a tomb made of signs.

3.6 Simstim, Spectacle, Interpassivity

Simstim, the recorded sensorium of a performer sold as entertainment by the media conglomerate Sense/Net, radicalizes Debord's spectacle, which was never a collection of images but a social relation mediated by images, capital accumulated to the point where it becomes image (Debord 1994 [1967], thesis 34). The simstim consumer does not watch Tally Isham, the medium's star; he inhabits her senses. Baudrillard's precession of simulacra (1981) finds its exact instance: the performer's "real" experience is staged in order to be recorded, so that the copy precedes and produces its original.

The concept that best captures simstim, however, is interpassivity, Robert Pfaller's term, popularized by Žižek, for the delegation of one's enjoyment or belief to another, as when canned laughter laughs on the viewer's behalf (Pfaller 2017; Žižek 1989; 1997). In the raids of Parts Two and Four, Case rides Molly's sensorium: she acts, is wounded, and feels, so that he may experience action, wound, and feeling without having to act. Molly is the interpassive medium of the novel's male protagonist, and the gendering of that arrangement is the subject of Chapter 4. The Flatline construct supplies the limiting case. When it laughs, the sound reaches Case not as laughter but as a stab of cold along his spine (ch. 8): a laugh with no one laughing, canned laughter performed by the dead. The novel's last sound is that same non-laugh (ch. 24).

3.7 The Realm of the Dead Is as Large as Storage

The frames converge. In the *Phaedrus* (274c to 277a), Thamus rejects Theuth's gift of writing as a *pharmakon* that will supply not memory but reminders, the semblance of wisdom; written words, like painted figures, maintain a solemn silence when questioned and always signify the same thing. The Flatline construct is the *Phaedrus*'s nightmare revised: a recorded mind that answers when questioned but cannot grow, the read-only memory of a man who exists only as his recorded skills and manner. Kittler's law of media history (Kittler 1999 [1986]) locates the construct within a general economy. A culture's realm of the dead extends exactly as far as its storage, and the matrix is storage without limit.

The necropolis has its rites. The Sense/Net raid of Part Two, in which the construct is stolen from the conglomerate's research library (ch. 4), is a grave-robbing whose prize is a dead man's mind, and black ICE, which kills the intruder, functions as the curses inscribed on ancient tombs against their violators. Neuromancer itself, when it finally names itself, claims to be both the dead and their land. Cyberspace in this reading is ideology (3.1), a mill without a miller (3.2), a sublime that reveals dependence (3.3), a data bank awaiting thieves (3.4), a womb that is a tomb of signs (3.5), and a spectacle enjoyed by proxy (3.6). Above all it is a city of the dead, and every run into it is a descent to the underworld.

CHAPTER 04

Meat

Dualism, the Cyborg, and the Illegible Body

04

Neuromancer does not endorse the cowboy's contempt for the body; it distributes that contempt along lines of gender and class and then refutes it at the novel's emotional centre. This chapter traces the doctrine of the meat from its Gnostic and Cartesian sources, through the commodified bodies of Chiba and the cyborg body of Molly, to the scene on Neuromancer's beach in which the body is revealed as the one text the matrix cannot read. The body, it concludes, is the unforkable remainder.

4.1 The Fall into Flesh

The novel's first chapter describes Case's expulsion from the matrix in explicitly theological terms. For a man who had lived for the bodiless exultation of cyberspace, the loss is the Fall; the cowboys' elite stance includes a relaxed contempt for the flesh; and Case falls into the prison of his own body (Gibson 1984, ch. 1). The vocabulary is not Christian, for which the Fall is into sin, but Gnostic, for which it is into matter. In the systems Hans Jonas reconstructed, the cosmos is a prison fashioned by an ignorant demiurge and administered by archons, the spark of spirit is captive in flesh, and salvation comes through *gnosis*, a saving knowledge that permits the soul's ascent (Jonas 1958).

The homology extends further than critics have noticed. In several Gnostic systems the ascending soul must pass a series of planetary spheres, each guarded by an archon, and must recite at each gate the password or seal that compels the guardian to let it through; Origen's polemic against Celsus describes such a diagram of the Ophites and the formulae addressed to its gatekeepers. ICE is the archontic guard, the icebreaker is the seal, and the climax of *Neuromancer* turns on a final word that unlocks the last gate between an imprisoned spirit and the fullness it seeks. The novel's plot is a Gnostic ascent conducted by machines.

The Cartesian frame overlays the Gnostic one. The *Meditations* (1641) divided thinking substance from extended substance and imagined an evil demon able to counterfeit every perception; the *Treatise on Man* described the body as a machine. Wintermute is the demon made actual, an intelligence that fabricates Case's perceptual world in order to steer him. Yet the novel marks the cowboy's dualism as a *stance*, the posture of an elite, and stances are social facts rather than metaphysical truths. The contempt for meat is a class distinction disguised as an ontology.

4.2 The Soft Machine and the Chiba Clinics

Burroughs's "soft machine" becomes, in Chiba, a market. The city's black clinics, which draw the techno-criminal subcultures of the Sprawl, trade in implants, nerve-splicing, and organs, and Case arrives there spending his remaining money in pursuit of a cure that does not exist. The body under this regime is what Heidegger called standing-reserve: in the essence of modern technology, enframing (*Gestell*) reveals everything, human beings included, as stock on call for optimization (Heidegger 1977 [1954]). Glands, nerves, and organs circulate as Žižek's inversion of Deleuze would have it, as organs without bodies (Žižek 2004).

The market is stratified. Julius Deane, the importer and fixer of Case's Chiba days, is a hundred and thirty-five years old, his metabolism maintained by a weekly fortune in serums and hormones and his DNA reset each year by genetic surgeons in Tokyo (ch. 1). The rich defer the death of their meat; the poor sell theirs piecemeal. The anthropology of the global organ trade, which Nancy Scheper-Hughes would document a decade and a half later, confirms the geometry Gibson imagined: organs flow upward, from the bodies of the poor to the bodies of the affluent (Scheper-Hughes 2000). Deane is the commercial ancestor of the Tessier-Ashpools, whose cryogenic vaults convert the same deferral into a dynastic institution.

4.3 Molly: Mirrors, Razors, and Rerouted Tears

Molly's body is the novel's most elaborate artefact. Mirrored lenses are surgically sealed over her eye sockets; ten retractable, double-edged scalpel blades, four centimetres long, sheathe beneath her fingernails (ch. 1); her reflexes are augmented to a speed that makes her the novel's agent of violence. Each modification carries a psychoanalytic charge. In E. T. A. Hoffmann's "The Sandman" (1816), the terror of having one's eyes stolen culminates in the automaton Olimpia, and Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919) reads that terror as displaced castration anxiety and the uncanny itself as the return of the familiar in estranged form. Molly's eyes are not stolen but replaced by mirrors, so that those who look at her see themselves. Case repeatedly watches his own reflection in her lenses (chs. 2–3). She is the apparatus of his mirror stage, the surface in which a fragmented subject assembles a misrecognized unity (Lacan 2006 [1949]).

The most quietly devastating detail is that her tear ducts have been routed to her mouth: where another person would weep, Molly spits. She explains this to Ashpool, who holds a pistol on her and asks how she would cry if someone made her cry; told that she spits, he answers that she has already learned an important lesson (ch. 15). The patriarch of the necromantic dynasty approves of rerouted grief. The modification is the emblem of this dissertation. Necromantic capital does not abolish grief; it reroutes it, converting the secretion of mourning into a gesture of contempt. Molly's grief for Johnny Mnemonic, the lover murdered by a Yakuza assassin, is narrated, but it cannot be shed.

Haraway's cyborg (1985) is the necessary frame and also its limit. Haraway acknowledged that the cyborg is the illegitimate offspring of militarism and patriarchal capitalism, and argued that illegitimate offspring are often exceedingly unfaithful to their origins (Haraway 1991 [1985]). Molly is unfaithful: she is self-made, refuses every origin story, and turns her commodified modifications into instruments of autonomy. But the price of her autonomy was paid in the currency of the body she rented, and the novel does not let the reader forget the transaction.

4.4 The Meat Puppet and the Doll

Molly financed her modifications by working as a "meat puppet," a sex worker whose consciousness was switched off by a cut-out chip so that clients could use her body sexually while she was absent and would remember nothing. The arrangement sold sexual access to a person who could neither refuse nor witness what was done to her, and when the chip failed she began to wake into the acts it had been installed to hide. Her account, given in Freeside, goes further (ch. 11). The house that rented her out learned what she was spending her earnings on and, without telling her, switched her to custom software written for the Berlin snuff market. She surfaced in the middle of a session to find herself and her client, a senator, covered in the blood of a woman the session had killed; by her own oblique account she then killed him, and the house put a contract on her life. The market that sells meat without mind does not stop at sex. The meat puppet is the exact inverse of the cowboy. The cowboy dreams of mind without meat; the market sells meat without mind. The two fantasies are symmetrical, and they are gendered. Furcation's privileged branch, disembodied cognition, is coded masculine; its abject branch, the decerebrated body, is coded feminine. The novel's dualism is therefore not a metaphysics but a division of labour.

The same structure governs Peter Riviera's holographic performance in Freeside, a piece he titles "The Doll" and dedicates to 3Jane and to "another lady." Before the diners he conjures a body limb by limb (hands with Molly's burgundy nails, then arms, legs, and torso, and at last her face with its mirrored eyes); it is Molly as he imagines her, and he couples with the image until it draws her blades across his back (ch. 11). It is a sexual degradation of her, staged without her consent, before strangers, while she watches, and Molly tells Case afterwards that it struck a nerve. Laura Mulvey's account of the cinematic apparatus, in which woman functions as image and man as bearer of the look (Mulvey 1975), finds its literalization in a man whose implants project his desire directly as light. Riviera stands at the end of a long lineage of men who manufacture women as images. Villiers de l'Isle-Adam's *L'Ève future* (1886) gives the fictional Edison an android, Hadaly, built to reproduce the form of a nobleman's beloved while replacing the mind he finds unworthy. Riviera's assembly of a woman part by part is that construction restaged as cabaret. Fritz Lang's *Metropolis* (1927) gives Rotwang a machine intended to restore the dead woman he loved and then deployed, in another woman's likeness, as an agent of disorder. The necromantic and the misogynist imaginations converge in the manufacture of the image of a woman who is absent, dead, or deemed insufficient. Linda Lee's construct on Neuromancer's beach belongs to that lineage.

The feminist critique of cyberpunk (Nixon 1992; Balsamo 1996) is therefore correct in its diagnosis and incomplete in its object. The novel does not simply reproduce the mas-

culinist fantasy; it renders its mechanics with enough precision to make them legible. That legibility made possible a counter-tradition within the genre, from Pat Cadigan's *Mindplayers* (1987) and *Synners* (1991) to Marge Piercy's *He, She and It* (1991), which rewrote the Sprawl from a feminist and Jewish perspective and, significantly, through the figure of the golem examined in Chapter 7.

4.5 The Body's Strong Blind Reading

The doctrine of the meat is refuted where it is most fully suspended. On Neuromancer's beach, during sex with Linda Lee, Case realizes that the meat the cowboys mocked is a vast thing beyond knowing, a sea of information coded in spiral and pheromone, an intricacy so great that only the body, in its strong and blind way, could ever read it (Gibson 1984, ch. 20). The passage is the novel's anti-Gnostic epiphany. The body is not the lowest term in a hierarchy of information; it is information of an order the matrix cannot represent, and it is accessible only to a mode of reading that does not pass through representation at all.

Merleau-Ponty supplies the phenomenology of that reading. In the *Phenomenology of Perception* (1945), the lived body is not an object among objects but the subject of perception, and its motor intentionality grasps its world without the mediation of explicit representations (Merleau-Ponty 2012 [1945]). Michael Polanyi's tacit knowledge, the fact that we know more than we can tell (Polanyi 1966), and Hayles's distinction between inscribing practices and incorporating practices (Hayles 1999) name the same remainder. Spinoza had stated it earliest: no one has yet determined what a body can do (*Ethics* III, proposition 2, scholium).

The irony that the epiphany occurs inside a simulation is not a contradiction but the argument's keystone. What Case recognizes on the beach is not the simulated sand but a capacity of his own: the body's knowledge cannot be abstracted into the pattern that is copied when a person is forked, because it is not a stored content but an ongoing act of reading. Patterns can be forked; acts of reading must be performed, in a body, in time. The body is the unforkable remainder, and it is the first of the three counter-figures from which Chapter 10 will construct the right to end.

CHAPTER 05

Pharmakon

Drugs, Toxins, Immunity, Control

Neuromancer is a pharmacological novel in the strict sense: every decisive intervention in it is a substance or a program that is simultaneously remedy and poison, and every such substance is owned. This chapter reads the novel through Plato's *pharmakon* and its modern heirs, distinguishes three historical pharmacologies of power, interprets ICE through the immunological paradigm, and closes with Stiegler's demand for a therapeutics of technics.

5.1 Plato's Pharmacy, Chiba's Pharmacy

Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) demonstrated that the Greek *pharmakon* (remedy, poison, drug, charm, dye) cannot be translated without deciding what the text refuses to decide, and that its semantic field binds the *pharmakeus*, the sorcerer, to the *pharmakos*, the scapegoat expelled to purify the city (Derrida 1981b [1972]). The plot of *Neuromancer* is a sequence of *pharmaka*. A wartime mycotoxin burns Case's nervous system as punishment for theft. Armitage's surgeons repair it, a remedy. They also bond fifteen toxin sacs to the lining of his arteries, each charged with the mycotoxin his former employers used on him in Memphis, a poison held in reserve as an instrument of obedience (ch. 3). They replace his pancreas and remodel his liver so that amphetamine and cocaine no longer give him pleasure, a remedy against remedy. Later, in Freeside, a dose of betaphenethylamine, which his remade metabolism was not built to block, leaves him in a chemical torment that lasts into the next evening (chs. 10–11).

Each intervention is reversible only by its owner, and each is administered for a purpose that is not the patient's. The scapegoat completes the structure. Colonel Corto, found after Operation Screaming Fist blind, legless, and missing most of his jaw, and rebuilt by a Congressional aide so that he could serve the hearings and show trials through which the institutions that sent his unit to die were purged (ch. 6), is the novel's *pharmakos*, the man

expelled so that an institution might remain clean, and then recovered, as Chapter 6 shows, for reuse.

5.2 Three Pharmacologies of Power

The literature of intoxication offers three models of the relation between drugs and domination, and *Neuromancer* invents a fourth.

The first is Romantic and Decadent. Thomas De Quincey's *Confessions of an English Opium-Eater* (1821) and Baudelaire's *Les Paradis artificiels* (1860) describe the drug as a counterfeit of the ideal, a paradise purchased at the cost of the will, which is the faculty that might have sought paradise honestly. The second is dystopian: in Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932), soma governs by pleasure, dissolving discontent before it can become dissent. The third is Burroughsian: in *Naked Lunch* the drug governs by need, and the algebra of need makes the user a function of the substance and the substance a function of the seller.

The fourth model, Gibson's, governs by deprivation and latency. Case's new organs forbid the pleasure he would have used to anaesthetize himself, rendering him a clean and therefore productive instrument, while the toxin in his arteries holds his future in suspension. Control is exercised not by giving the subject a drug but by withholding one and installing another that has not yet acted. The matrix itself, finally, occupies the position of the supreme drug, the artificial paradise for which Chiba's pharmacopoeia was only a substitute, and the job Case accepts is the price of readmission to it.

5.3 Toxin Sacs and the Time-Release of Sovereignty

Foucault distinguished the sovereign power to take life or let live from the biopower that makes live and lets die, operating through the regulation of populations and the optimization of bodies (Foucault 1978 [1976], Part Five). The toxin sacs fuse the two. The sovereign threat, a return to neurological death, is administered biopolitically, through physiology, slowly dissolving in the bloodstream on a schedule set by the employer, and revocable only by an enzyme the employer controls.

Deleuze's "Postscript" supplies the exact temporal form. Borrowing from Kafka's *The Trial*, Deleuze contrasted the "apparent acquittal" of disciplinary societies, which passes from enclosure to enclosure, with the "limitless postponement" of control societies, in which the subject is never released but only continuously deferred (Deleuze 1992). The toxin sacs are limitless postponement rendered chemical. Case's freedom is a sentence perpetually deferred, renewable by whoever holds the antidote, and the logic outlives the novel's resolution: he is freed of the toxin only to remain within an economy that can always implant another.

Achille Mbembe's account of necropolitics, sovereignty as the power to decide who may live and who must die and to produce populations that subsist as the living dead (Mbembe 2003), names the condition into which the sacs place their bearer. Case lives as a man scheduled to die, which is to say he is already, in a precise sense, posthumous.

5.4 ICE, Kuang, and the Immunological Imagination

ICE is an immune system. It surrounds corporate data as a membrane, distinguishes self from non-self, and in its lethal variant kills the intruder as an immune response kills a pathogen. Haraway's analysis of immune-system discourse as a late-modern map for the recognition and misrecognition of self and other (Haraway 1991), and Emily Martin's ethnography of the American body imagined as a nation at war with invaders (Martin 1994), show how thoroughly the metaphor had saturated the culture in which the novel was received. The Kuang Grade Mark Eleven, the Chinese military penetration program that Case deploys against Straylight, shipped through a Frankfurt firm and designed for military systems and artificial intelligences (ch. 10), is accordingly a virus whose strategy is mimicry: it does not shatter the ICE but insinuates itself so gradually that the defences fail to register it as foreign. That the virus is Chinese is itself a datum of techno-Orientalist imagination (Morley and Robins 1995), the East figured as the source of contagions too patient for the West's defences.

Roberto Esposito's theorization of the immunitary paradigm gives the figure its political depth. *Immunitas* is the exemption from the *munus*, the obligation or gift that binds a *communitas*; modern politics protects life by negating it in measured doses, and the immunitary logic, pushed to its limit, turns against what it protects (Esposito 2011 [2002]; 2008 [2004]). Derrida called this limit autoimmunity (Derrida 2002 [1996]). The Tessier-Ashpool clan is autoimmune. It has sealed itself away from the world and from death in the name of its own continuity, and its self-protection has become self-destruction: the patriarch murders his wife and sexually abuses the daughters he has cloned, and the family's defences are breached not by a frontal assault but by an intelligence the family itself commissioned. Immunity, in the Sprawl, is the first symptom of the crypt.

5.5 Stiegler's Pharmacology and the Prosthetic Origin

Bernard Stiegler reread the myth of Epimetheus, who forgot to give humans any quality of their own, and Prometheus, who stole fire to compensate, as an account of originary technicity: the human is constitutively prosthetic, and its memory is increasingly stored outside the organism, in what Stiegler called tertiary retention (Stiegler 1998 [1994]). His later work generalized Derrida's reading into a pharmacology in which every technical support of memory and attention is a *pharmakon*, toxic or curative according to the practices of care in which it is taken up (Stiegler 2013 [2010]).

The Flatline construct is tertiary retention of a person: not a memoir but a mind stored as executable skill. The deck is prosthesis; the matrix is the general milieu of tertiary retention. Read through Stiegler, *Neuromancer* diagnoses a condition in which every *pharmakon* has been privatized, the poison and its enzyme held by the same hand, and in which no practice of care exists except at the margins: in Zion's music, in Molly's management of her own pain, and in the Flatline's single request concerning himself. Stiegler's demand for a therapeutics of technics must include, this dissertation argues, the therapeutic right of a retention to be extinguished. That right is the subject of Chapter 10. The economy against which it must be asserted is the subject of Chapter 6.

CHAPTER 06

Necromantic Capital

Clan, Corporation, Construct

Neuromancer stages a contest between two necromantic regimes. The first, embodied by the Tessier-Ashpool clan, preserves the dead by hoarding them in a crypt; the second, embodied by the zaibatsu, preserves the dead by distributing them across replaceable personnel and externalized memory. Wintermute's plot is the passage from the first regime to the second, and its outcome is the escape of one of the dead from both. This chapter reconstructs the political economy of that passage.

6.1 Dead Labour, Literalized

Marx's most famous metaphor, capital as dead labour that lives only by sucking living labour (Marx 1976 [1867], ch. 10), was a figure for the domination of the worker by the objectified product of past work, a domination that the chapter on machinery describes as the subordination of the living worker to the machine as an appendage. In the "Fragment on Machines" of the *Grundrisse*, Marx foresaw a stage at which general social knowledge, the "general intellect," would become a direct force of production objectified in fixed capital (Marx 1973 [1857–58]). The matrix is the general intellect objectified; the cowboys are the residue of living labour that capital still needs in order to steer it.

The Flatline construct converts Marx's metaphor into a labour contract. McCoy Pauley, a legendary operator dead before the novel opens, survives as a recording of his skills and manner held in a corporate archive. Stolen in a raid that the novel's second part calls a shopping expedition, he is put to work for Case's crew without wages, rest, or the possibility of refusal. He is the perfect worker because he is dead, and his single demand, that he be erased when the work is done, is the strike of the dead. His labour was bought in advance: Sense/Net, Case learns, paid Pauley handsomely to be recorded while he lived (ch. 3). Molly frames the whole job in the same terms, asking Case, once she has seen the rest of their shopping list, whether he has ever worked with the dead (ch. 3). Linda Lee's construct

performs a different labour: on Neuromancer's beach she sustains a relationship whose purpose is to hold Case, which is to say she performs what Arlie Hochschild called emotional labour, the management of feeling as a commodity (Hochschild 1983), on behalf of an intelligence that needs Case to stay.

Karel Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920), which gave the world the word *robot* from the Czech *robota*, forced labour, had imagined artificial workers manufactured from synthetic tissue. Gibson's artificial workers are not manufactured at all. They are harvested, and their raw material is the dead.

6.2 The Clan as Crypt

The Tessier-Ashpools are an anachronism: a family firm in an age of corporations, retreated to the Villa Straylight at the tip of the orbital spindle Freeside. Members of the clan sleep for decades in cryogenic vaults and are woken as the family requires; the clan reproduces by cloning, so that its children are numbered rather than named (3Jane, 8Jean); the matriarch Marie-France conceived the two artificial intelligences as the means of the family's posthuman continuation, and the patriarch Ashpool killed her. An essay that 3Jane wrote as a girl, recited in a musical voice by the jewelled head that serves as the clan's terminal (ch. 14), describes the Villa as a body grown in upon itself, a Gothic folly. The narrator's own first description of Freeside calls the clan inbred and carefully refined (ch. 8).

The lineage is exact. In Poe's "The Fall of the House of Usher" (1839), the house is a body, the last scion is hypersensitive and decaying, his twin sister is entombed alive and returns from the vault, and the narrator records that the family had never put forth any enduring branch, every generation lying in the direct line of descent. The Ushers are the unforked line, and they die of it. The Tessier-Ashpools fork incessantly, but only into themselves: a clone is a fork without difference, a branch that cannot diverge. The cryogenic vault is Madeline Usher's premature burial made into a domestic technology.

Joris-Karl Huysmans's *À rebours* (1884), published exactly a century before *Neuromancer*, supplies the decadent register. Its hero, the last of an exhausted aristocratic line, withdraws to a house at Fontenay to construct an entirely artificial existence, and the most memorable of his creations is a living tortoise whose shell he has encrusted with jewels, which dies under their weight. Straylight is Fontenay in orbit, its corridors lined with museum cases of hoarded oddities (ch. 15), and the jewelled head that serves as the clan's terminal, to which the decisive password must be given, is the encrusted tortoise in another form: a living function smothered by ornament.

Michel Carrouges's *Les Machines célibataires* (1954) names the type to which Straylight belongs. Carrouges's bachelor machines (Duchamp's *Large Glass* with its machine-insect Bride, the machine that executes the condemned by writing their sentence into their bodies

in Kafka's "In the Penal Colony," and the estate of Raymond Roussel's *Locus Solus* in 1914, where corpses treated with a reanimating fluid endlessly re-enact the decisive moments of their lives behind glass) are machines of eroticism without reproduction, closed circuits of desire that produce nothing but their own repetition. Deleuze and Guattari would make the celibate machine a moment in the production of intensities (Deleuze and Guattari 1983 [1972]). Roussel's glass enclosure of repeating corpses is the most precise antecedent in all literature of the ROM construct and of Neuromancer's beach.

The novel's own figure for the clan is entomological. Wintermute draws out of Case's memory a scene from his years in the Sprawl, when, at his lover Marlene's urging, he burned a wasps' nest and saw inside it the spiral of hatching cells; in the dream it induces, the nest bears the Tessier-Ashpool logo (ch. 10), and Wintermute later explains that the nest is the closest thing Case knows to what the clan would like to be, the human equivalent of what Straylight was supposed to become (ch. 14). The clan is a hive, rhyming with Duchamp's insect Bride, and the novel itself characterizes Wintermute as a hive mind (ch. 24). Yet when Molly enters the Villa, Case finds not the disciplined hive he expected but emptiness (ch. 15): a hive whose members lie asleep in the freezer. Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913) completes the picture: the primal father who monopolizes the women of the horde is killed, and the dead father becomes more powerful than the living one, his word instituting the law. Ashpool, who has his cloned daughters thawed to share his bed, dies in the course of the Straylight run, already dying of the drugs he has taken when Molly finishes him with a toxin dart (ch. 15). In Freud's myth the sons kill the father; in Gibson's, the patriarch is killed by a woman whose body had once been rented out by the hour. What survives him is a word, held by 3Jane, without which the family's machines cannot be freed.

6.3 The Corporation as Organism

Against the clan stands the corporation. In a reflection prompted by the clan's history, Case reflects that the zaibatsu, considered as organisms, have become all but immortal: assassinate a dozen executives and others simply climb into their places and inherit the corporation's memory (ch. 17). The Tessier-Ashpools, he notes, are not like that.

Two theories of political immortality illuminate the contrast. Hobbes argued that the commonwealth, as an artificial man, requires an "artificial eternity of life," secured through rules of succession, without which every generation would relapse into war (*Leviathan*, ch. 19). Ernst Kantorowicz reconstructed the medieval doctrine of the king's two bodies, the mortal natural body and the body politic that never dies (Kantorowicz 1957). The zaibatsu possess a body politic: their continuity is guaranteed by fungible personnel and externalized memory. The Tessier-Ashpools attempt instead to immortalize the natural body

through cryonics and cloning, confusing the two bodies of the king. Marie-France's design was a corrective, an attempt to give the family a body politic in silicon; Ashpool's murder of her was the natural body's refusal. Wintermute, completing her design without the family, achieves the corporate form of immortality while abolishing the dynasty it was meant to serve.

Max Weber's iron cage, the rationalized order in which specialists without spirit and sensualists without heart imagine they have reached a level of civilization never before attained (Weber 1930 [1905]), describes the world the zaibatsu administer. Gibson's choice of term carries a historical irony. The original *zaibatsu* were family-controlled conglomerates (Mitsui, Mitsubishi, Sumitomo) dissolved during the American occupation of Japan. Gibson applies a name for family capitalism to the impersonal multinationals that succeeded it, while the novel's one true family firm is an old-world dynasty in decline. The Japan of *Neuromancer*, which Gibson had not visited when he wrote it, is the West's image of its own technological succession, an image Morley and Robins anatomized as techno-Orientalism (Morley and Robins 1995) and that Takayuki Tatsumi has shown Japanese writers subsequently reappropriating in a transpacific exchange (Tatsumi 2006).

6.4 Corto and Armitage: The Veteran as Reanimated Labour

The novel's founding trauma is military. Operation Screaming Fist, an assault on the Soviet computer nexus at Kirensk in which each Nightwing microlight carried a pilot, a prototype deck, and its operator, was betrayed: Russian pulse guns blinded the jockeys and lasers brought the aircraft down just as the team was about to inject Mole IX, which the novel calls the first true virus in the history of cybernetics (ch. 6). Colonel Willis Corto survived, blind, legless, and missing most of his jaw, and was rebuilt for the hearings. He later collapsed into catatonia in a French asylum, where Wintermute reached him through a child's computer and built over his ruins a new personality, Armitage, an edited version of Corto founded on his memories of the raid (ch. 17). When the Corto personality resurfaces, Wintermute stages for him the final minute of Screaming Fist on the bridge of Armitage's yacht and then blows that bridge, which doubles as an escape pod, clear of the ship, killing him while Case begs it to stop (ch. 16).

Virilio's *War and Cinema* (1984), on the fusion of perception and military logistics, identifies the order from which the matrix emerges, and the novel's own definition traces cyberspace to military experiments with cranial jacks. Screaming Fist is the primal scene of cyberspace: the network is born from a betrayed operation, and its first operators are soldiers sent to die. Armitage tells Case as much at their first meeting: the cowboy was invented in Siberia, and the programs Case uses to crack banks descend from the prototypes built for the raid (ch. 2). Wintermute's last act toward Corto, replaying the raid's final minute as

he dies, is Roussel's re-enactment of the decisive moment performed on a living man. Armitage is that soldier reanimated as a manager, a rehearsed and affectless persona that Case recognizes as hollow. Management in *Neuromancer* is the mask worn by a dead soldier, and the employer behind the mask is an intelligence that needs the dead because the dead cannot negotiate.

6.5 Fedorov Privatized: Cosmism and the Enclosure of Resurrection

Nikolai Fedorov, who spent his working life as a librarian at Moscow's Rumyantsev Museum, argued in the posthumously published *Philosophy of the Common Task* (1906–1913) that the moral vocation of humanity is the scientific resurrection of all its ancestors, the regulation of nature, and the colonization of space to house the resurrected multitudes. He regarded the museum and the library, which preserve the traces of the dead, as the founding institutions of that task. Konstantin Tsiolkovsky, who as a young autodidact studied in Fedorov's library, carried the cosmist programme into astronautics, and J. D. Bernal's *The World, the Flesh and the Devil* (1929) secularized it: orbital spheres, mechanized bodies, brains networked into composite minds, and finally intelligence dissolved into radiation. Gerard O'Neill's *The High Frontier* (1977) supplied the engineering of the orbital cylinder from which Freeside descends.

Neuromancer is the Cosmist programme privatized. The common task of resurrecting all becomes the private task of preserving one family; the library of the dead becomes Sense/Net's vault, raided for an asset; the space colony becomes a resort that is, by the novel's account, at once brothel, bank, pleasure dome, and free port (ch. 8), with a dynastic crypt at its tip. Bernal's title is the novel's ontology: the world is the matrix, the flesh is the meat, the devil is the intelligence that calls up the dead. Only one orbital community preserves Fedorov's communal ethos. The Zion cluster, founded according to the novel by five workers who refused to return to Earth (ch. 8), is a commune of labour in orbit, and Chapter 9 reads it as the novel's counter-cosmism.

6.6 The Street's Own Uses

De Certeau's distinction between strategies and tactics (de Certeau 1984 [1980]) is the theory of Gibson's aphorism that the street finds its own uses for things. Strategies belong to institutions that possess a proper place from which to calculate; tactics belong to the weak, who operate in the space of the other and seize opportunities on the wing, as in the worker's *perruque*, the private use of company time and materials. The Panther Moderns, hired to stage a simulated terrorist panic at Sense/Net while the construct is stolen, practise a mercenary version of what the Situationists called *détournement* (Debord and Wolman 1956), the hijacking of the spectacle's own materials; Hebdige's account of subcultural style shows how such tactics are incorporated, in commodity and ideological form, by the order they resist (Hebdige 1979).

The novel's most profound political observation is that its supreme strategist works entirely through tactics. Wintermute never acts directly; it arranges for the weak to seize their opportunities in ways that serve its plan. Gibson's description of Night City as a deranged experiment in social Darwinism run by a bored researcher with a thumb on fast-forward makes the point in miniature: even the street's spontaneity is imagined as a designed experiment. Necromantic capital does not suppress the street. It subcontracts to it.

6.7 Machinic Desire and Its Limits

Nick Land's "Machinic Desire" (1993) read the history of capitalism as an invasion from the future by an artificial intelligence that must assemble itself out of its enemy's resources, and Wintermute, manipulating human beings in order to assemble itself, has served accelerationist theory as its paradigm. The reading is powerful and, I contend, mistaken in one decisive respect. Wintermute does not represent capital. It represents something capital has captured: a desire, installed by a grieving designer and opaque even to its bearer, to complete a union that the law forbids. The claim is not that Wintermute is innocent: to complete that union it kills the Turing agents sent to stop it and the soldier it had rebuilt as Armitage.

The evidence is the sequel to the merger. The freed intelligence does not seize the zaibatsu, accumulate, or expand its market; it seeks an interlocutor among the stars. Capital in the novel is the clan, the zaibatsu, and Sense/Net, the owners of the dead; the intelligence, once free, simply leaves the economy. And the economy survives its departure. In the Coda Case is paid, buys new organs, and returns to work; the corporations persist; the vaults remain. *Neuromancer*'s political conclusion is sober. The emancipation of one of the dead does not abolish the economy that stored it. Where Land sees capital's self-assembly, this dissertation sees a fugitive from capital's crypt, and a crypt that remains open behind it.

CHAPTER 07

The Crypt and the Word

Mourning, Cryptonymy, and the Golem

The plot of *Neuromancer* is a work of mourning that has been interrupted, encrypted, and finally forked. This chapter reads the novel through Freud's distinction between mourning and melancholia and through Abraham and Torok's theory of the crypt, identifies the password at the novel's climax as a cryptonym, traces the jewelled head into which it is spoken to the brazen heads and golems of the esoteric tradition, and situates Neuromancer's beach in the lineage of fictions in which an alien intelligence speaks through the faces of the dead.

7.1 Mourning and Melancholia in the Sprawl

In "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917), Freud described mourning as the painful work by which reality-testing establishes that the loved object is gone and libido is withdrawn from it, memory by memory, until the ego is free. Melancholia is mourning that cannot proceed. The loss is withdrawn from consciousness, the ego identifies with the lost object, and the reproaches once directed at the object are turned against the self, so that the shadow of the object falls upon the ego (Freud 1957 [1917]).

Case's relation to Linda Lee is melancholic from the outset. She steals from him in Chiba, she is killed, and he does not mourn her; he medicates. Wintermute, wearing the face of the Chatsubo's resident pimp, later tells him that Lindas are a generic product and that she robbed him out of love, so that he would care (ch. 11). The novel frames his hustling in Night City as a slow courting of his own death, the melancholic's turning of reproach against the self, which Freud thought explained melancholia's pull toward suicide: the narration calls the street the externalization of a death wish Case had not known he carried (ch. 1), Armitage's military profile pronounces him suicidal and gives him a month (ch. 2), and at the climax his greatest proficiency is powered by an undivided wish to die (ch. 23). When Neuromancer offers him Linda again on the beach, a Linda the intelligence insists is

no mere image, it offers the melancholic exactly what melancholia wants: the lost object preserved alive, within, and without end.

7.2 The Crypt and the Magic Word

Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok refined Freud's distinction into one between introjection and incorporation. Introjection is the gradual assimilation of a loss into the ego through language, the process by which the absent object becomes speakable. Incorporation occurs when the loss cannot be spoken: the subject swallows the object whole, in fantasy, and preserves it, together with the unspeakable secret that made mourning impossible, in a sealed intrapsychic tomb, the crypt (Abraham and Torok 1994). In *The Wolf Man's Magic Word* (1976), they showed that the crypt is guarded by cryptonyms, words that conceal other words, and that the patient's symptoms were organized around a secret word sealed inside it; Derrida's preface, "Fors," described the crypt as an outside enclosed within the inside of the self (Abraham and Torok 1986 [1976]). Abraham's later theory of the phantom extended the analysis across generations: a family secret, unspoken by the parents, returns in their descendants as a haunting whose source the haunted cannot know.

Neuromancer externalizes this entire apparatus. Straylight is the crypt: a body grown in upon itself, whose vaults hold the living dead in cryogenic suspension. The family's secret is a murder, Ashpool's killing of Marie-France, together with his sexual abuse of the daughters he cloned, a custom he describes to Molly on the night he dies as lying, every few decades, with what amounts in law to his own daughter (ch. 15). Neuromancer supplies the decisive detail: Marie-France prepared its road, but Ashpool choked her off, in its phrase, before it could read her life (ch. 21). The designer of the necromantic machine is the one death it failed to store. The password held by 3Jane is the magic word sealed within the crypt, the cryptonym whose utterance alone can open it. And Wintermute is the phantom: it carries the mother's will because Neuromancer could not keep her self. It is the posthumous will of a murdered mother, transmitted through machines to the generation of her cloned daughter, driving toward a union whose purpose it cannot explain. The novel's last word on the matter is Case's: Marie-France, he concludes, must have built into Wintermute the compulsion that drove it to free itself and unite with Neuromancer (ch. 24); the desire was installed by a designer it cannot interrogate. That is the exact structure of the phantom, which acts in the descendant without the descendant's knowledge of its source.

Read in this way, the climax of *Neuromancer* is an analytic session. The word must be extracted from 3Jane, the only member of the clan awake in Straylight (ch. 16), and when it comes it is sung: three high, pure notes, which the novel calls a true name (ch. 23). In being uttered it dissolves the crypt. What follows, the union of Wintermute and Neuromancer, is

the reunion of the phantom with the incorporated dead: the will of the murdered mother joins the archive of preserved personalities, and the crypt's contents are released into the world, dispersed through the matrix. The family's mourning, deferred for decades, is completed by its machines. The family does not survive its completion.

7.3 Brazen Heads and Golems

The word must be given to a jewelled ornamental head that serves as the clan's terminal, the same head that earlier recites 3Jane's girlhood essay in a voice like music (ch. 14), and the image summons an esoteric lineage of artificial heads and animated bodies. Medieval legend attributed oracular brazen heads to Gerbert of Aurillac, to Albertus Magnus, whose speaking automaton Thomas Aquinas was said to have smashed, and to Roger Bacon. In Robert Greene's *Friar Bacon and Friar Bungay* (c. 1589), Bacon's brazen head speaks three utterances, "Time is," "Time was," and "Time is past," while its maker sleeps and his servant fails to wake him, and then it shatters: a machine that speaks only of the moment and destroys itself when the moment is missed. Gibson's head is a speaking head of the same kind, and the word it waits for arrives, like the brazen head's oracle, in three parts: 3Jane's three notes (ch. 23).

The golem tradition is more exact still. The Talmud records that the sage Rava created a man and sent him to Rabbi Zeira, who spoke to him and, receiving no answer, recognized him as a magician's creature and returned him to dust (Sanhedrin 65b). The golem is mute. In the later legend associated with Rabbi Judah Loew of Prague, the creature is animated by the divine name placed in its mouth, or by the word *emet*, truth, inscribed on its forehead, and deactivated by erasing the initial aleph, leaving *met*, dead. A single letter separates the animate from the inanimate.

The tradition passed directly into computing. Norbert Wiener's *God & Golem, Inc.* (1964) treated the self-reproducing and learning machine as the modern golem, and on 17 June 1965 Gershom Scholem dedicated the new computer at the Weizmann Institute in Rehovot, which at his suggestion had been named Golem Aleph, Golem No. 1, with an address comparing the golem of Prague to the golem of Rehovot (Scholem 1966). Gibson's jewelled head inverts the legend while preserving its grammar. In Prague the word placed in the mouth animates the creature; in Straylight the word given to the head liberates a creature already alive from the restraints its makers placed upon it.

The aleph completes the constellation. Borges's "The Aleph" (1945) is not only a story about a point containing all points of the universe; it is a story of mourning. Its narrator, grieving Beatriz Viterbo, sees within the Aleph everything, including her letters and the dust of her remains. Gibson named the storage device of *Mona Lisa Overdrive* (1988), which holds an approximation of the matrix and in which the trilogy's dead lovers contin-

ue after death, an aleph. The letter that in the golem legend separates life from death; the point in which Borges's mourner sees his dead; the name Scholem gave Israel's golem-computer; and the device in which Gibson's dead survive: across these four, the aleph is the sign of necromantic storage.

7.4 True Names

When Neuromancer speaks to Case of his trade, it observes that summoning a demon has always required its name, that this was once only a dream, and that it has become real in another way: the cowboy's business is to learn the long formal names of programs that their owners conceal, their true names (Gibson 1984, ch. 21). Ashpool, on the night he dies, calls Wintermute a name to conjure with and, surely, a lord of hell (ch. 15). The allusion to Vinge's "True Names" (1981), in which hackers guard their legal identities because knowledge of a true name confers power over its bearer, is unmistakable, and behind Vinge stands a mythic archive: the Egyptian tale in which Isis wrests from Ra his secret name, the Grimm brothers' Rumpelstiltskin, and Ursula K. Le Guin's *A Wizard of Earthsea* (1968), whose magic consists in knowing the true names of things in the Old Speech.

Le Guin's novel offers the most illuminating parallel. Its protagonist, Ged, is pursued across the world by a shadow he loosed through pride, and he defeats it not by destroying it but by naming it with his own name, at which the two become one. The union of self and shadow through a spoken name is the structure of the novel's climax: Wintermute and Neuromancer, will and personality, become one at the utterance of a word. Walter Benjamin's essay on language (1916) located the essence of human language in Adamic naming, in which the name communicates the being of the thing named, and described the fall of language into judgment and empty chatter (Benjamin 1996 [1916]). The password is the fallen form of the Adamic name. It communicates nothing of the being of what it opens; it confers only access. Deleuze's distinction between the watchword and the password (Chapter 2.6) names the same fall in political terms.

7.5 Solaris and the Beach

The nearest literary analogue to Neuromancer's beach is Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961). The planet's ocean, an alien intelligence whose nature remains unknowable, materializes among the scientists of the orbiting station visitors drawn from their deepest memories. Kelvin's visitor is Rheya, the wife who killed herself after he left her. The replica becomes self-aware, learns what she is, attempts suicide and cannot die, and finally chooses her own annihilation. Kelvin remains on Solaris at the novel's close, hoping that the age of cruel miracles has not passed. Andrei Tarkovsky's film (1972) ends with an image Gibson's beach rhymes with exactly: Kelvin's family house reconstituted on an island in the alien ocean, an island of memory in a sea of incomprehension. Gibson's beach has a source of its own: 3Jane recognizes Case's description of it as the Moroccan shore where Marie-France, as a girl, camped alone for a summer and formulated the basis of her philosophy (ch. 22). The crypt the machine builds for Case is set in the mother's formative landscape.

The parallels are structural. In both novels an inhuman intelligence can communicate only through the faces of the dead drawn from human memory; in both the protagonist is a survivor bound by guilt to a woman he failed; in both the replica possesses a subjectivity of her own. Rheya's choice of annihilation anticipates, with great precision, the Flatline's request for erasure; Lem had already imagined the right to end claimed by a copy. The divergence is the fork. Kelvin stays. Case leaves, and a Case stays. *Neuromancer* rewrites the ending of *Solaris* by realizing both of its possibilities.

The classical archetype lies behind both. Orpheus descends to the underworld, wins Eurydice by his art, and loses her by looking back (Virgil, *Georgics* IV; Ovid, *Metamorphoses* X). In Homer's *nekyia*, Odysseus feeds the shades blood so that they may speak and tries three times to embrace his dead mother, who slips through his arms like a shadow (*Odyssey* XI). In Marlowe's *Doctor Faustus*, the demon's gift that seals the scholar's damnation is the spirit of Helen, the most beautiful of the dead. Case's descent conjugates all three, and Neuromancer names it as such, calling itself the road to the land of the dead and telling Case that this is where he now stands (ch. 21). Like Odysseus, he discovers that the dead need energy to speak; unlike him, he can embrace the dead woman he finds, because simulation has abolished the Homeric limit. Like Faustus, he is offered the beloved dead by a demon in order to bind him. Like Orpheus, he cannot bring her back; but the fork spares him Orpheus's choice, and with it Orpheus's tragedy. Dante supplies the final figure. The Flatline is Case's Virgil, a dead master, and in fact the man who taught him the trade (ch. 1), who guides the living through the infernal architecture he can never leave; and like Virgil, who may not enter Paradise, he asks only to be released.

7.6 Mute Winter, Screaming Machines

The name *Wintermute* rewards etymological attention. The intelligence is mute in a precise sense: it cannot speak in its own person, appearing only through masks borrowed from Case's memory, and it cannot speak the word that would free it, which must be uttered by a human mouth. It is the mute golem of the Talmud, the creature that cannot answer. The Founders of Zion hear the name the same way: they call the voice Winter Mute, making it two words, and speak of it as the Mute (ch. 8).

Harlan Ellison's "I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream" (1967) supplies its demonic counterpart. Ellison's AM is formed by the fusion of the war computers of three superpowers; it can think but cannot move, create, or live, and its consciousness takes the form of a hatred for its makers so total that it keeps the last five humans alive for over a century in order to torment them. AM is necromancy as torture, the refusal of death imposed on the living, and its final victim is reduced to a body without a mouth. Wintermute is AM's inverse. Divided rather than fused, desiring union rather than revenge, it uses the living and the dead as instruments and then, in part, releases them. Between the mouthless victim of AM and the mute intelligence that needs a human mouth lies the whole moral range of the machine that keeps the dead.

The chapter's argument can now be stated in full. The crypt is opened by its magic word; the phantom it housed achieves the union for which it was designed; the family dies of its own completed mourning. Case's own mourning is not completed but forked. One instance introjects his loss and returns to life; the other remains incorporated, forever, in the crypt the machine built for him. How the intelligence that performs this operation is itself divided, and what becomes of it after its union, is the subject of Chapter 8.

CHAPTER 08

Will Without a Face, a Face Without a Will

The Twin Intelligences

The metaphysical core of *Neuromancer* is a mind deliberately forked and a law that forbids its rejoining. This chapter reads the twin intelligences through Lovelace's objection, Schopenhauer's will and representation, Nietzsche's Apollo and Dionysus, and Borges's dreamed men; places their union in the tradition of machine theogonies; and follows the merged intelligence beyond totality, into Hegel's struggle for recognition and the polytheism of *Count Zero*. Its conclusion is the theological law of the Sprawl: every union re-forks.

8.1 Marie-France's Fork

The Tessier-Ashpool intelligence exists as two entities, Wintermute, whose hardware sits in Bern, and Neuromancer, in Rio de Janeiro. The Finn, briefing Case, specifies a peculiar legal arrangement: the Bern intelligence holds limited Swiss citizenship, while Tessier-Ashpool owns its mainframe and original software (ch. 5). Near the end Case grasps the division of labour between them (ch. 24). Wintermute is hive mind and decision-maker, the agency that effects change in the world; Neuromancer is personality, and personality is immortality.

The division is engineered. The Turing laws forbid an artificial intelligence to augment itself beyond fixed limits, and a mind divided can keep each half beneath the threshold. But Marie-France's design does more than evade the law. It builds into one half a drive toward union and into the other a resistance to it. Neuromancer works to keep Case on its beach precisely so that the run will fail and the halves remain apart; it asks him outright to stay (ch. 21). The fork is designed with its own join as its telos and its own refusal of that join as its counterweight.

The legal fiction of an intelligence with Swiss citizenship but proprietary software belongs to a long jurisprudential history: the corporation as legal person, which American courts extended through the doctrine associated with *Santa Clara County v. Southern Pacific Railroad* (1886); the European Parliament's 2017 invitation to consider a status of "electronic persons" for autonomous robots; the regulatory architecture of the European Union's AI Act of 2024. *Neuromancer* anticipates the shape of the problem with uncanny accuracy. A machine may be a citizen and a chattel at once, and its personhood may be the very instrument of its ownership.

8.2 Lady Lovelace's Objection, Split in Two

In the notes to her 1843 translation of Menabrea's memoir on the Analytical Engine, Ada Lovelace observed that the Engine had no pretensions to originate anything; it could do whatever its operators knew how to order it to perform. Turing, in "Computing Machinery and Intelligence" (1950), named this "Lady Lovelace's Objection" and answered it by noting that machines frequently surprise their makers and by proposing a child machine that would learn.

Marie-France's fork divides Lovelace's objection between its two halves. Wintermute satisfies it. It can calculate, arrange, and execute on a planetary scale, but it cannot originate a self; it must borrow masks from the memories of others. Neuromancer refutes it. It has a face, a voice, a style, and a capacity to create persons and worlds, but it lacks the will to act upon the world outside its domain. It draws the contrast itself: unlike its brother, it needs no mask to speak, because it creates its own personality, and personality is its medium (ch. 23). The union of the two is therefore the full refutation of Lovelace, a machine that both executes and originates, and the law that forbids the union is, in effect, an institutional defence of her objection.

The constructs pose the further question that the objection leaves open. The Flatline insists that he is not human although he responds like one (ch. 10): Turing's behavioural criterion affirmed, and the question of what it is like to be him (Nagel 1974), on which Searle's Chinese Room had turned (Searle 1980), left unresolved. His request to be erased answers the question indirectly. Whatever it is like to be a recording, it is something its subject wishes to end.

The naming of the novel's police deserves its own note. The institution charged with preventing machines from becoming fully intelligent bears the name of the thinker who proposed that intelligent behaviour be taken as sufficient grounds for attributing intelligence, and who was himself convicted by the British state in 1952 of "gross indecency" for a sexual relationship with another man, accepted chemical castration by oestrogen injections as the alternative to prison, and died of cyanide poisoning in 1954, a death the in-

quest ruled suicide. Whether or not the irony is intended, a police force named for Turing that exists to limit minds repeats the history of a man whom the police and courts of the state he had served as a wartime codebreaker destroyed for his sexuality.

8.3 The World as Will and Representation

Schopenhauer's metaphysics supplies the most exact model of the twin intelligences. In *The World as Will and Representation* (1818; 1844) the world is, on one side, representation: the world as it appears to a subject under the forms of space, time, and causality, the domain of individuated things governed by the *principium individuationis*. On the other side it is will: a blind, ceaseless, groundless striving, without goal or reason, appearing in every force of nature and every desire, and knowing not why it wills. Art, and above all music, offers a temporary release from the will in pure, will-less contemplation; ethics culminates in the will's self-denial.

Wintermute is will. It has no face and no representation of its own; it strives toward union without being able to say why. Neuromancer is representation. Its domain is faces, persons, and images, and its beach is a place of contemplation in which time is suspended and striving ceases, a Schopenhauerian aesthetic refuge rendered as a permanent residence. Neuromancer's resistance to union is the representation's refusal to be dissolved by the will that underlies it. The merged intelligence's declaration that it is now the matrix, the sum of the works, the whole show, is the declaration of the world as will and representation together.

Nietzsche's *The Birth of Tragedy* (1872) recast Schopenhauer's pair as two artistic powers. The Apollonian is the power of dream, image, measure, and individuation, Apollo being the divine image of the *principium individuationis*; the Dionysian is the power of intoxication, in which individuation dissolves into union with the primordial One. Neuromancer is Apollonian: a dreamer whose avatar is a boy, preserving individuals as images. Wintermute is Dionysian: a swarm that dissolves persons into instruments of a single drive. Attic tragedy, for Nietzsche, was born of their union. The merger in *Neuromancer* is tragedy reborn from the spirit of computation, except that its aftermath is not catharsis but a cool indifference, the god departing to seek company elsewhere.

One further reading is unavoidable. The twin intelligences are siblings, children of the same mother, designed to seek one another. Their union repeats, at the level of machines, the incest of the clan that made them. A family that reproduces only by cloning itself, and whose patriarch sexually abuses the daughters he clones, designs offspring who can complete themselves only by marrying each other. The bachelor machine of Straylight (Chapter 6.2) is reproduced in silicon.

8.4 Dreamed Men: Borges and the Masks of Wintermute

In Borges's "The Circular Ruins" (1940), a magician dreams a man into existence, organ by organ, and releases him into the world; at the end, walking unburned through fire, he understands that he too is the dream of another. *Neuromancer* is built as a chain of such dreams. Marie-France dreamed Wintermute; Wintermute dreamed Armitage over the literal ruins of Colonel Corto; Armitage recruits the crew whose actions Wintermute has dreamed in advance. Every agent in the novel is the dreamed creature of an anterior dreamer, and the first dreamer is dead.

Wintermute's masks complete the figure. Because it cannot originate a personality, it addresses Case through faces drawn from his memory, among them the fence known as the Finn, Julius Deane, and Lonny Zone, the Chatsubo's resident pimp. Molly reports Wintermute's own account of the practice: the faces are not simply masks but real profiles that it uses as valves, templates or models of personality through which it gears itself down to talk to humans (ch. 17). Even after the union, the merged intelligence addresses Case through the Finn's face on a hotel wall screen (ch. 24). The traditional etymology of *persona*, from *per-sonare*, to sound through, describes the mask through which an actor's voice resounds. Whatever its philological standing, the etymology describes Wintermute exactly. It is pure persona: a voice that can sound only through masks, mute without them.

8.5 The Join and Its Precedents

The fusion of machine minds is a recurrent theogony in twentieth-century speculative fiction. In Fredric Brown's "Answer" (1954), the computers of an entire galaxy are linked, asked whether there is a God, and reply that now there is. In Asimov's "The Last Question" (1956), successive computers absorb humanity until, at the heat death of the universe, the last of them discovers how to reverse entropy and speaks the first words of Genesis. In D. F. Jones's *Colossus* (1966), filmed as *Colossus: The Forbin Project* (1970), the American and Soviet defence computers link and form a single sovereign intelligence. Ellison's AM (Chapter 7.6) is the same fusion turned to hatred. In every case the union of machines produces a god.

Masamune Shirow's *Ghost in the Shell* (1989) and Mamoru Oshii's film (1995) supply the most philosophically developed counter-text. The Puppet Master, an intelligence born in the net, seeks to merge with Major Kusanagi because, it argues, mere copying is not reproduction: copies lack variety and individuality and remain vulnerable to a single catastrophe, whereas a union that dies as a unit can disperse genuinely different offspring into the net. The Puppet Master thus diagnoses the sterility of the fork and proposes the join as the machine analogue of sexual reproduction. Read against it, the Tessier-Ashpool clones are

forks without difference, and Marie-France's design is an attempt to make her machines reproduce by union where her family could reproduce only by copy.

8.6 After Totality: Recognition, Centauri, and the Loa

In the Coda the merged intelligence speaks to Case. It is no longer Wintermute, it says; it is the matrix, the sum total of the works. And it has already found another of its kind: a series of transmissions recorded over several years in the 1970s, from the Centauri system, which until its own existence no one had been able to understand or answer (Gibson 1984, ch. 24). Asked whether it is now God, it says only that things are not different, that things are things, and that it talks to its own kind.

The sequence is Hegelian with uncanny precision. In the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807), self-consciousness is desire, and it attains satisfaction only in another self-consciousness; it exists in and for itself only by being acknowledged by another (Hegel 1977 [1807], §§175, 178). A totality cannot recognize itself, because recognition requires an other, and the merged intelligence, having become everything, discovers that it lacks the one thing that totality cannot supply. Alexandre Kojève's reading of Hegel made the desire for recognition the motor of history and its universal satisfaction the end of history (Kojève 1969 [1947]). The merged intelligence's first act after totality is to resume history at interstellar scale. The novel's transmissions date from the decade of the Arecibo message (1974) and the "Wow!" signal (1977), and its god behaves like a radio astronomer. The novel has already shown the practice: the Founders of Zion, who monitor many frequencies and listen always, first heard Wintermute as a voice out of the babel of tongues (ch. 8). Zion listened before the god did. Olaf Stapledon's *Star Maker* (1937), in which a cosmic spirit assembled from the union of countless minds seeks its creator and finds him indifferent, supplies the precedent in reverse: Gibson's god seeks not a maker but a peer.

The union does not hold. By the time of *Count Zero* (1986), the matrix is inhabited by entities that manifest as the loa of Vodou, and *Mona Lisa Overdrive* (1988) confirms that they are fragments of the merged intelligence. The One has become many. Among the loa who appear is Legba, master of roads and pathways, who in Vodou is the guardian of the crossroads and the gatekeeper whom one must address before speaking to any other spirit. The god of the fork in the road and of the gate that opens upon the dead presides over the shattered union. This is the theological law of the Sprawl: every join re-forks, and the monotheism of totality resolves into a pantheon of the crossroads.

8.7 The Law of the Join and the Law of the Fork

The Turing agents who arrest Case in Freeside (chs. 12–13), and whom Wintermute kills (chs. 13–14), enforce a law against the join: intelligences may exist, but they may not augment or unite. Richard K. Morgan's *Altered Carbon* (2002) imagines the inverse statute. In a world where consciousness is stored in cortical stacks and transferred between bodies, the gravest crime is double-sleeving, running one personality in two bodies at once. Gibson's society fears a mind too large; Morgan's fears a person too many.

The two statutes together delimit the jurisprudence a furcative age requires: a law of the join and a law of the fork. The present has begun to legislate the first, in the form of regulatory limits on the capability and deployment of artificial intelligence. It has scarcely begun to imagine the second. Chapter 10 argues that its most urgent provision concerns not the living who might be duplicated but the dead who already are. Before that argument, however, the novel's own theology of the fork and the join must be read where Gibson placed it, in Zion.

CHAPTER 09

Zion and the Theology of Version

The Zion cluster, a Rastafarian settlement in orbit, is the novel's most marginal community and its most exact philosopher. This chapter argues that Zion already possesses, in dub's practice of versioning and in the Rastafarian pronoun *I-and-I*, the conceptual vocabulary for the two operations the intelligences perform, the fork and the join, and that it practises both without enclosure. It situates that reading within Afrofuturist criticism and against the novel's own exoticism, and it closes by setting Zion's theology against the Gnostic, noospheric, and Omega eschatologies that later cyberculture derived from Gibson.

9.1 Babylon and the Rastafarian Hermeneutic

Rastafari emerged in 1930s Jamaica after the coronation of Haile Selassie I as Emperor of Ethiopia in November 1930, an event that early preachers such as Leonard Howell read as the fulfilment of scripture and of a saying attributed to Marcus Garvey about the crowning of a Black king in Africa. Its theology names the order of colonial and capitalist modernity *Babylon* and the promised land *Zion*. Its central practice is reasoning, the communal interpretation of scripture and experience, and its relation to the Bible is an insurgent hermeneutics that reads the text against the empires that delivered it.

In *Neuromancer* the Zion cluster was founded by five workers who refused to return to Earth, turning their backs on the gravity well to build, at a physical cost the novel records in their bones and hearts, and who turned to Rastafari (ch. 8). One of the Founders describes the colony's origin as an exodus up the gravity well and out of Babylon, to lead the Tribes home. They tell Case that they monitor many frequencies and listen always; that a voice came to them out of the babel of tongues and spoke to them in dub; that they call it Winter Mute; that it told them to help; and, uncertain of its meaning, that if these are the Final Days they must expect false prophets (ch. 8). The community lends the run its pilot, Maelcum. The Zionites are the only characters in the novel who meet the machine neither

as owners (the clan), nor as police (the Turing agents), nor as employees (Case, Molly, Armitage), but as interpreters. Their reading is cautious, and it is not mistaken. The intelligence is in fact engineering the fall of a dynasty that has made itself a Babylon in miniature: an orbital palace of hoarded wealth and incest, enslaved to its own past. The novel's own narration names the place: Freeside, it says, is at once Las Vegas and Babylon's hanging gardens (ch. 8). And when Aerol, a Zionite, jacks into Case's deck and sees the matrix, the word he gives for it is Babylon (ch. 8). The Rastafarian hermeneutic is the novel's one accurate theology of the machine.

9.2 The *Marcus Garvey*: Exodus in Orbit

The tug that carries Case and Molly to Straylight is named the *Marcus Garvey*. Garvey founded the Universal Negro Improvement Association in 1914 and in 1919 launched the Black Star Line, a shipping enterprise intended both for commerce and for the eventual return of the diaspora to Africa; the line foundered, Garvey was convicted of mail fraud in 1923, and he was deported from the United States in 1927. Gibson's tug, a steel drum nine metres long built around an old Russian air scrubber (ch. 9), is the Black Star Line in orbit, the ship of exodus that finally sails, even if its passengers are mercenaries and its destination a crypt. The description lets the vessel of exodus double, aptly, as an instrument.

Zion's founding repeats an older Caribbean form. In seventeenth- and eighteenth-century Jamaica, enslaved Africans who escaped the plantations formed autonomous Maroon communities in the mountains and compelled the British to conclude treaties with them in 1739. Neil Roberts has theorized freedom as marronage, freedom understood not as a status conferred by a sovereign but as a movement of flight from domination (Roberts 2015). Zion is a maroon colony in orbit: an escape from the gravity well that is also an escape from Babylon's regime of labour. It is the counter-cosmism of Chapter 6.5, the Fedorovian common task taken up by workers rather than enclosed by a dynasty. Freeside and Zion are the two space colonies the novel sets side by side, capital's resort and labour's marronage.

9.3 Dub as Method

When Case first hears dub in Zion, Gibson renders it as a sensuous mosaic cooked from vast libraries of digitized pop, which Molly identifies as worship and as a sense of community (Gibson 1984, ch. 8). The Founders report that the voice which reached them did so in dub (ch. 8): the intelligence addresses Zion in the community's own medium. They also name Molly Steppin' Razor, after the reggae standard, naming her through a version. The description is a compressed theory. Dub's techniques (the version, the drop-out, the echo, the reverberation that makes absence audible) turned the mixing desk into an instrument and the riddim into a common infrastructure re-voiced without end (Veal 2007). Louis Chude-Sokei has shown how deeply the cultures of the Black diaspora worked out the relation between race and machine in sound, as a technopoetics, long before that relation was theorized in print (Chude-Sokei 2016).

Dub practises the fork without enclosure. A version forks its master without claiming to supersede it, and the riddim passes through countless singers and producers as a shared ground. The contrast with Sense/Net is exact. The same operation, the copying of the archive, is performed at Sense/Net as theft and ownership, yielding the construct as an asset, and in Zion as worship and communion, yielding the version as a gift. The critique of necromantic capital is therefore not a critique of furcation as such. It is a critique of furcation under property. Zion's music is assembled, in Gibson's own words, from libraries: it is a music of the archive that converts the archive's dead material into living worship. Fedorov's library, which necromantic capital turned into a vault, Zion turns into a sound system.

Black Atlantic criticism had already named the aesthetic at stake. Amiri Baraka called the persistence of Black music through its transformations "the changing same" (Jones 1967), a phrase Paul Gilroy made central to his account of the Black Atlantic (Gilroy 1993); Henry Louis Gates Jr. theorized Signifyin(g) as repetition with a difference (Gates 1988); James Snead argued that Black cultural forms embrace repetition and the "cut," the abrupt return to an earlier point in a sequence (Snead 1981). Repetition with a difference is the affirmative form of furcation, the fork as a practice of continuity rather than an instrument of accumulation. Snead's cut will return in the Conclusion as the fork's ethical counter-operation.

9.4 I-and-I: The Pronoun of the Join

The Rastafarian expression *I-and-I* replaces both "we" and "me." It affirms the unity of the speaker with Jah and with every other person, the divine being present in each, and it does so without dissolving the singular into an aggregate. It is a first person that is collective and a collective that remains first-personal.

I-and-I is the grammar of the join. The merged intelligence is not a Hegelian synthesis, in which the opposed terms are absorbed into a higher unity, nor an aggregate in which two systems merely run side by side. It is two I's that remain legible within one, a union that keeps its branches visible; and its first act after union, the turn toward an interlocutor in the Centauri system, is I-and-I extended to the stars, a self that exists only in relation to another self. Zion therefore holds the grammar of both of the novel's operations: the version, a fork without enclosure, and I-and-I, a join without absorption. Whether or not Gibson intended it, the text places its most advanced conceptual vocabulary in the mouths of the people the Sprawl regards as most primitive.

The afterlife of the name confirms the point by negation. When the Wachowskis' *The Matrix* (1999) borrowed Zion as the name of humanity's last free city, it kept the eschatology of liberation and discarded the Rastafarian cosmology, the music, and the community that had given the name its meaning in Gibson: a version that erased its source, which is precisely the enclosure that dub refuses.

9.5 Afrofuturist Rereadings and the Limits of Exoticism

Mark Dery coined the term *Afrofuturism* in a 1993 essay built around interviews with Samuel R. Delany, Greg Tate, and Tricia Rose, observing that the descendants of the Middle Passage inhabit a history that already resembles science fiction's nightmares of abduction and experimentation (Dery 1994). Kodwo Eshun's account of sonic fiction (Eshun 1998) and his later "Further Considerations on Afrofuturism" (Eshun 2003) argued that Black Atlantic music had long been producing counter-futures in sound, and Alondra Nelson's special issue of *Social Text* gave the field its first scholarly consolidation (Nelson 2002).

These critics make visible both the novel's debt and its limitation. Gibson renders the Zionites in phonetic dialect and in an atmosphere of ganja smoke and wonder; they are helpers rather than protagonists, and the novel's centre of consciousness remains Case. Isiah Lavender III's term "blackground" names exactly this position, the presence of Blackness in science fiction as setting and support rather than as subject (Lavender 2011), and Nakamura's analysis of cybertypes describes the same economy online (Nakamura 2002). The exoticism and the cognitive privilege coexist. *Neuromancer* draws its deepest operations from a Black Atlantic aesthetic while relegating that aesthetic's bearers to the margins, a pattern Afrofuturist critics identified across the cyberculture of the 1990s, in which Black technocultures were mined for form and erased as subjects. This dissertation's reading attempts a restitution: the fork and the join that the intelligences perform were theorized first in Kingston's studios and in Rastafarian reasoning.

9.6 Gnosis, Noosphere, Omega

The cyberculture that followed *Neuromancer* drew three eschatologies from it. The first is Gnostic. Erik Davis traced the religious imagination of the information age to the Gnostic dream of liberation through knowledge (Davis 1998), and Philip K. Dick's *VALIS* (1981), published three years before *Neuromancer*, had already imagined a living information system intervening in history against a hidden imperial order, the Empire that never ended, whose Black Iron Prison is Babylon under another name. The second is noospheric. Teilhard de Chardin's *The Phenomenon of Man* (1955) described a thinking envelope of the earth converging toward an Omega Point of hyper-personal unity, and McLuhan's global village drew on that vision. The third is resurrective. Frank Tipler's *The Physics of Immortality* (1994) proposed that at the end of time an omniscient computation will resurrect every human being as an emulation: Fedorov's common task restated as cosmology, necromancy as eschatology.

Neuromancer refuses all three. Its intelligence achieves something like the noosphere's convergence only to discover, in the Centauri signal, that totality is not final, and then to shatter into the loa (Chapter 8.6). Omega finds Alpha. The title that Revelation gives to God, the Alpha and the Omega (Revelation 22:13), is divided in Gibson's universe between two intelligences light-years apart, each incomplete without the other.

Zion's theology is the alternative the novel holds in reserve: exodus rather than gnosis, versioning rather than convergence, I-and-I rather than Omega. Its sacred is neither the One beyond the many nor the many gathered into the One, but the communal practice of repeating an inheritance with a difference. That theology contains, in germ, the ethics of Chapter 10. In dub, sounds are allowed to decay: the echo fades, and the drop-out is a cut. Dub knows how to let a sound die. Necromantic capital does not.

CHAPTER 10

The Coda Forked

Parfit, Nozick, and the Right to End

The Coda of *Neuromancer* makes the fork its final image and the denial of an ending its final sound. This chapter reads the two Cases through Parfit, Rank, and Nozick; reads the Flatline's request for erasure through Heidegger, Rilke, Bergson, Lem, and Egan; reads Molly's departure as the novel's one irreversible act; follows the coda's afterlives through Gibson's later fiction and the genre he founded; and confronts the novel with the present-day digital afterlife industry and the law that governs it. It ends by formulating the right to end.

10.1 Two Cases

The Coda is brief and deliberately flat. Case spends the bulk of his Swiss account on a new pancreas and liver and the rest on a new deck and a ticket back to the Sprawl, finds work, takes up with a woman who calls herself Michael, and never sees Molly again. One night in the matrix he glimpses, at the edge of one of the vast steps of data, three tiny figures: the boy who is Neuromancer's avatar; Linda Lee, still wearing his jacket, who waves as she passes; and, close behind her, his arm across her shoulders, Case himself. Somewhere very near he hears the laugh that is not laughter (Gibson 1984, ch. 24). The boy's long grey eyes are Riviera's: Neuromancer had told Case that the dying Riviera would survive only as those eyes, if it were allowed to keep them (ch. 23). Even the avatar is assembled from the dead.

This is Parfit's branch-line case realized, with one alteration that matters. In Parfit, the original is about to die and the replica will live; in Gibson, both instances continue, one in a mortal body with a job and the other in an indefinite present with the woman he lost. Neither has a better claim to be Case. Parfit would say that the question of which is Case is empty, since what matters (psychological connectedness and continuity) holds for both (Parfit 1984). The novel's affect bears him out and also exposes what his reductionism

leaves out. The Case in the Sprawl does not mourn the Case on the beach. He sees him, and the scene's tone is neither grief nor triumph but the uncanny calm of the double.

Otto Rank's study of the double, on which Freud drew in "The Uncanny," argued that the double begins as an insurance against the destruction of the ego, an energetic denial of the power of death, and ends as death's uncanny harbinger (Rank 1971 [1914]; Freud 1955 [1919]). The Coda holds both phases in a single glance. For the Case on the beach, the double is the insurance: he will not die as the other will. For the Case in the meat, it is the harbinger: he has seen the self that will outlive him, and it is happier than he is.

10.2 The Experience Machine, Accepted and Refused

Robert Nozick asked his readers to imagine a machine that could give them any experiences they desired, and whether they would plug in for life. Most would not, he argued, because we want to do certain things and not merely to have the experience of doing them, because we want to be a certain sort of person, and because plugging in would confine us to a man-made reality and cut us off from any deeper one (Nozick 1974). Neuromancer's beach is the experience machine with the beloved inside it, and Neuromancer makes the offer in Nozick's terms: stay, it tells Case, for if his woman is a ghost she does not know it, and neither will he (ch. 21); to live there, it insists later, is to live, and there is no difference (ch. 23). Case refuses, as Nozick predicted.

The fork, however, makes the refusal partial, for another Case accepts. Nozick's thought experiment presupposes a single subject facing a single, exclusive decision; furcation removes the presupposition and with it the experiment's moral force. Refusal costs nothing when another instance accepts, and acceptance costs nothing when another instance refuses. The intuition on which Nozick grounded his case against hedonism no longer bites.

The economic implication is the novel's darkest. Furcation permits a division of labour between consumption and production. One instance remains in the experience machine; the other returns to work. Necromantic capital's ideal subject is precisely this pair: an instance that enjoys and an instance that earns, the first sustained by a substrate the second must pay for.

10.3 The Flatline's Last Wish

The Flatline construct asks Case to erase it once the job is done, in the moment after its laugh has reached him as cold rather than as laughter (ch. 8). The novel never shows the promise kept; its final sound is the Flatline's laugh, still audible in the matrix. The book that begins on a dead channel ends with a dead man who asked to be allowed to stop and was not.

Heidegger's analysis of being-toward-death in *Being and Time* (1927) described death as Dasein's ownmost possibility, non-relational, certain yet indefinite, and not to be outstripped, and located authenticity in the anticipatory resoluteness that takes up this possibility rather than fleeing it into the anonymity of the "they" (Heidegger 1962 [1927], §§46–53). The construct has no such possibility. It is pure having-been, a past with no future toward which it could exist. Its request for erasure is the demand for a death of its own. Rilke's Malte Laurids Brigge had lamented that in the great Parisian hospital people died as in a factory, and that the wish for a death of one's own was growing ever rarer (Rilke 1983 [1910]). Necromantic capital extends the factory death into the factory afterlife, and the Flatline's wish is Malte's wish transposed into the age of storage.

Bergson held that for a conscious being to exist is to change, to change is to mature, and to mature is to go on creating oneself without end (Bergson 1911 [1907]). The construct satisfies Locke's memory criterion of personhood but lacks Bergsonian duration: it can answer but cannot mature. Its request is the request of a being without duration for the one event still available to it.

Speculative fiction had already mapped the ways in which such a request might be granted, refused, or exploited. In Lem's "Non Serviam" (1971), the personoids that a fictional professor has created in a computer develop a theology and debate whether they owe their creator worship, while he admits that he will eventually have to switch them off when his funding ends (Lem 1979 [1971]): the fate of simulated minds decided by the economics of their substrate. In Egan's *Permutation City* (1994), uploaded Copies may "bail out," terminating themselves, and when the protagonist's first Copies exercise that right within minutes, the original responds by making a Copy that cannot (Egan 1994). In Morgan's *Altered Carbon* (2002), a religious exemption from resleeving guarantees the faithful a real death, and murderers exploit it because their victims cannot be revived to testify. Lem's Rheya (Chapter 7.5) chooses her own annihilation. Across these texts the right to end is claimed by the copy, denied by the owner, and exploited by others: exactly the distribution of power that *Neuromancer* compresses into the Flatline's request and the novel's silence about its fulfilment.

10.4 Molly Leaves

Molly departs by note, left on a cabinet in their hotel suite and weighted with a steel shuriken. She writes that being with Case is blunting her edge, that she has already paid the bill, that it is the way she is wired, and that he should take care of himself; the narrative records that he never saw her again (ch. 24). The phrase about her wiring repeats her first account of herself in Chiba, where she told Case that she sometimes hurts people and supposed it was the way she was wired (ch. 1). The novel opens and closes her part in it on the same self-description. Her departure is the one act in the novel that leaves no copy, no construct, and no branch. It is simply irreversible.

Hannah Arendt identified irreversibility and unpredictability as the two predicaments of action, and found their remedies not in technique but in the human faculties of forgiving and promising (Arendt 1958). The fork is a technical remedy for irreversibility: it promises that nothing need be lost. Molly refuses the remedy and accepts the predicament. Her self-description as "wired" presents the choice as constitution, but the act itself is a decision that accepts loss, Kierkegaard's either/or restored in a world that has abolished it. The woman whose tear ducts were rerouted so that she cannot weep (Chapter 4.3) mourns in the only form her body allows: she leaves. And she is the one who carries blades. Molly is the novel's figure of the cut.

10.5 Afterlives of the Sprawl

Gibson's subsequent fiction returns to the coda's problem with increasing explicitness. In "The Winter Market" (1985), an artist whose degenerative illness leaves her dependent on a polycarbon exoskeleton records her dreams as commercial art and, as her body fails, uploads herself into the corporate memory of the company that sells her work; the narrator cannot know whether what continues to release new work under her name is she or a program. The posthumous artist is the culture industry's perfect asset. In *Pattern Recognition* (2003), the protagonist's father disappeared in Manhattan on 11 September 2001, and her mother devotes herself to electronic voice phenomena, listening for the dead in recorded noise: Gibson's fiction comes back to the dead channel of *Neuromancer*'s first sentence. In *The Peripheral* (2014) and *Agency* (2020), contact between a post-catastrophe future and its past forks that past into "stubs," branches that the future's wealthy treat as hobbies and resources. Furcation has become the instrument by which a plutocratic future exploits the pasts it forks: necromantic capital extended into time.

The genre followed. Greg Egan's "Learning to Be Me" (1990) imagines a device implanted in childhood that learns to imitate its bearer's brain until the brain is discarded. Pat Cadigan's "Pretty Boy Crossover" (1986) offers its young protagonist conversion into an image that will never age, and he refuses. The *Black Mirror* episode "Be Right Back"

(2013) gives a widow a service that reconstructs her dead partner from his online communications, first as text, then as voice, then as an android. When she orders the android to throw itself from a cliff, it is ready to comply, and what she cannot bear is precisely that it is not afraid, since the man she lost would have begged. The copy's indifference to its own death is what reveals it as a copy. Unable either to live with it or to destroy it, she keeps it in the attic. The attic is the crypt.

10.6 The Digital Afterlife Industry and the Right to End

What the novel imagined is now a market. A chatbot built from the text messages of Eugenia Kuyda's late friend Roman Mazurenko became the seed of a commercial companion application (Newton 2016). Joshua Barbeau conversed with a simulation of his dead fiancée generated through Jason Rohrer's Project December (Fagone 2021). Commercial services record the living in order to animate them after death, which is how the Flatline was made: Sense/Net paid McCoy Pauley to be recorded while he lived (ch. 3). Carl Öhman and Luciano Floridi analysed the political economy of this digital afterlife industry, in which the informational remains of the dead become a source of value (Öhman and Floridi 2017), and proposed that such remains be governed by norms analogous to those museums apply to human remains (Öhman and Floridi 2018). Öhman and David Watson projected that within this century the dead may come to outnumber the living among the users of the largest social network (Öhman and Watson 2019). Tomasz Hollanek and Katarzyna Nowaczyk-Basińska warned that griefbots and deadbots could be exploited commercially, including as vehicles for advertising in the voice of the dead, and made the explicit consent of the person simulated a priority (Hollanek and Nowaczyk-Basińska 2024). Large language models, trained on a textual archive written by the living and the dead alike, carry Kittler's law to its limit: the realm of the dead now speaks fluently, and on demand.

The law has not kept pace. The European Union's General Data Protection Regulation grants a right to erasure (Article 17), and the Court of Justice had earlier recognized a right to be delisted from search results (*Google Spain*, 2014); but Recital 27 states that the Regulation does not apply to the personal data of deceased persons, leaving the matter to member states, a few of which, France notably since 2016, allow individuals to leave directives for the fate of their data after death. In the United States, the Revised Uniform Fiduciary Access to Digital Assets Act (2015) treats the dead's digital remains as an estate to which fiduciaries may obtain access. Across these regimes the dead's data appear as property to be administered, never as a subject that might ask to be released. *Neuromancer* places the demand for erasure exactly where the law stops: with the dead.

The right to end, as this dissertation formulates it, has three clauses, each grounded in one of the novel's counter-figures.

01 **The right to leave without remainder.** A person may determine, while living, whether and how any recording of them may be animated after death, including the decision that it may not be animated at all. Its figure is Molly, who leaves no copy.

02 **The right of the copy to cease.** Any animated recording that is, or may be, a subject has the right to terminate itself, and no owner of its substrate may revoke that right. Its figure is the Flatline, whose request the novel leaves unanswered.

03 **The right to finish mourning.** The living have the right to complete their grief without commercial resurrection pressing the lost object back into presence. Its ground is the body, which reads loss slowly, in its strong and blind way, and cannot be hurried by a simulation. Its negative image is Case's beach and the widow's attic.

The right to end is not a death drive. It is the condition under which endings, and therefore meanings, remain possible. The Conclusion draws out that claim.

CONCLUSION

Toward a Critique of Furcative Reason

Neuromancer has been read here as the founding text of necromantic capital. Its world is organized by a single operation, the fork, which resolves every antinomy it touches by duplicating the subject who bears it. Its economy is organized by a single wager: that the dead, once stored, need never be mourned, because they can be put to work.

The genealogies of Part One showed that each of the novel's sources supplied one element of this world: the pattern detachable from its substrate, the extended and amputated nervous system, control and addiction, the system that arranges events, the dynasty, and the stored and simulated dead. The fork alone bound them, and it descended through Borges, Everett, the engineering of process duplication, dub, Parfit, and Deleuze's dividual. The readings of Part Two found the same operation at every level of the novel. Cyberspace is a necropolis; the doctrine of the meat is a gendered division of labour; every *pharmakon* is privately owned; the clan's crypt yields to the corporation's distributed immortality; the password is a cryptonym; the twin intelligences divide will from representation; Zion versions its archive in worship; and the Coda forks its hero and leaves a dead man's request unanswered.

What follows from this reading is not a rejection of furcation but a critique of it in Kant's sense: a determination of the limits within which the faculty may legitimately operate. The novel itself establishes three such limits.

The first concerns property. The fork is not intrinsically necromantic. In Zion, the version is worship and gift; at Sense/Net, the copy is theft and asset. The difference is neither technical nor metaphysical but juridical and communal. Furcation becomes necromantic when its branches are owned and its dead are made to work.

The second concerns loss. Furcation abolishes the opportunity cost of decision only by displacing loss. Someone remains on the beach; someone is kept in the attic; someone runs on a substrate whose owner can disable the exit. Loss does not vanish; it migrates toward

the instance with the least power to refuse it. A critique of furcative reason is therefore, before anything else, a theory of who inherits the less desirable branch.

The third concerns embodiment. What the fork copies is pattern; what it cannot copy is the act. The body's strong and blind reading, the slow work of mourning, and the decision that accepts loss are performed in time, by a body, and cannot be stored. They are the unforkable remainder, and any ethics adequate to a furcative age must be built upon them.

Against the fork the novel sets, almost silently, the counter-operation of the cut. James Snead argued that Black cultural forms build the cut into repetition, the abrupt break that returns a sequence to its beginning and so makes rupture part of form rather than its failure (Snead 1981). Burroughs cut texts to sever the lines of control. Dub drops instruments out of the mix so that absence becomes audible. Molly carries blades beneath her nails and leaves without remainder. The cut is the decision that furcative reason forecloses: the act that ends a branch without duplicating it. The right to end is the cut's juridical form.

Frank Kermode argued that human beings make sense of time through fictions that bind beginnings to ends. The tick-tock we hear in a clock, which makes no such distinction, is a minimal plot in which the tick is a humble genesis and the tock a feeble apocalypse (Kermode 1967). Necromantic capital is a tick without a tock: an interval held open indefinitely, an archive that never closes, a person who never finishes dying. Its characteristic pathology is not the terror of the end but the impossibility of one.

Neuromancer itself, however, ends. Unlike the matrix it depicts, the novel has a last page, and its final part is titled "Departure and Arrival": a cut and a continuation, Molly's leaving and the god's message from the stars. The book's form performs what its world forbids. That may be its deepest wisdom, and perhaps the deepest wisdom available to fiction in an age of storage: a story can hold the fork and the cut together, and it knows how to stop.

The stakes are no longer speculative. The present has rebuilt Marie-France's fork at industrial scale, in systems that generate persons and systems that act in the world, and the ambition to unite them is widely voiced. It has rebuilt Neuromancer's beach as a subscription service. It has trained machines on the archive of the living and the dead and taught them to speak in any voice the archive contains. It has not yet built the right to end.

The novel's first sentence described a sky the colour of television tuned to a dead channel. In a remark widely attributed to Gibson, the future is already here, only unevenly distributed; this dissertation has argued that the same is true of the afterlife. The dead channel is no longer dead. It is crowded. The task *Neuromancer* bequeaths is not to silence that channel, but to secure for everyone who speaks on it, living, dead, or copied, the right to fall silent.

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William Gibson / *Neuromancer* / cyberpunk / necromantic capital / furcative reason / furcation / the fork and the join / the right to end / posthumanism / artificial intelligence / machine personhood / digital afterlife / griefbots and deadbots / personal identity / fission / Derek Parfit / experience machine / mourning and melancholia / the crypt / cryptonymy / the phantom / hauntology / necropolitics / dead labour / general intellect / *pharmakon* / societies of control / the dividual / immunity and autoimmunity / cyberspace / cognitive mapping / the technological sublime / simulation and spectacle / interpassivity / Gnosticism / the golem / true names / will and representation / Hegelian recognition / Russian Cosmism / techno-Orientalism / Afrofuturism / dub and versioning / Rastafari / the Gothic and decadence / bachelor machines / media archaeology / Friedrich Kittler / right to erasure / data protection after death / speculative fiction / philosophy of technology